

Not All Contact Is Equal: Interaction with Natives and Immigrant Political Integration in Hostile Contexts *

Younghyun Lee

PhD Candidate, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign

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Abstract

Immigrants learn to see themselves as members of the political community from the people they live among, mainly natives, who are the established majority of the host society. The natives who welcome immigrants are often the same natives who vote for the party that campaigns against them. Using separate 2021 and 2022 German Socio-Economic Panel samples and optimal full matching, I compare immigrants who report different levels of contact with natives but share similar backgrounds and live in similarly hostile districts. I show that (1) immigrants who report positive interactions with natives trust institutions more than matched immigrants who do not; (2) immigrants with mostly native friends report stronger attachment to Germany than matched immigrants with mostly migrant friends; and (3) the two types of hostility do different work. Where the AfD vote is high, immigrants with positive contact trust institutions no more than matched immigrants who do not. Where natives are very concerned about immigration, immigrants with mostly native friends feel less attached to Germany than matched immigrants with mostly migrant friends. Interviews with Syrian and Turkish immigrants suggest why: in hostile places, the more native friends immigrants have, the more of that rejection reaches them through people they trust. Scholars of contact theory have mainly asked how contact reduces prejudice among the majority. I ask what contact does for immigrants themselves, and find that the answer depends on the level of societal and political hostility immigrants are exposed to.

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1 Introduction

"If I feel connected to Germans, then why shouldn't I feel connected to Germany?"

– Selin (pseudonym), Turkish immigrant in Germany

The political environment around immigrants in contemporary Europe has grown more hostile: anti-immigrant parties have gained ground, restrictive policies have spread, and immigration has become a central electoral issue (Akkerman, 2015; Grande et al., 2019; Krzyżanowski & Ekström, 2022; Lee et al., 2026). Immigrants meet this hostility mostly at a distance, in election results and in the news. And the same immigrants have natives¹ as neighbors, coworkers, and friends, and many of these relationships are warm. The natives an immigrant knows can all be kind while the district she lives in votes for a party that campaigns against people like her. These two facts coexist in the same districts, often in the same lives. How does that coexistence relate to immigrants' political integration? Do people who are welcomed in person but rejected in public come to trust the country's institutions, feel able to influence them, and see themselves as members of the political community?

Much of what we know about integration comes from studying its formal side: citizenship rules, language requirements, and labor-market access (Goodman & Wright, 2015; Hainmueller et al., 2017). These factors shape immigrants' legal standing and material opportunities, but say little about how immigrants come to feel like members of a political community. Everyday interactions with natives may provide that information. Natives are both the majority whose attitudes and votes constitute the broader context and the neighbors, coworkers, and friends through whom immigrants learn how they are regarded.

We know a great deal about how hostile environments erode immigrants' political integration. Exclusionary rhetoric depresses immigrants' sense of political belonging (Simonsen, 2021), restrictive policies targeting minority practices weaken identification with the host society (Abdelgadir & Fouka, 2020), xenophobic appeals push immigrants away from the political mainstream (Pérez, 2015), and hostility can distort rather than advance assimilation (Fouka, 2019). These studies examine hostility primarily as a feature of the broader environment. But immigrants do not experience their new country only as a climate. They experience it as particular people: the neighbor, the coworker, the friend. We do not know whether those relationships buffer immigrants from broader hostility or expose them to it more directly. In this paper, I ask: *how does interpersonal contact with natives relate to immigrants' political integration, and how does this relationship vary with the level of anti-immigrant hostility in the local context?*

I define political integration as the attitudinal process by which immigrants come to see themselves as members of the political community of the host society (Simonsen, 2017), beyond the act of voting (Liu, 2021), encompassing political trust, political interest, political efficacy, and a sense of belonging (Dollmann, 2022). I distinguish two forms of hostility. Political hostility is visible in electoral support for anti-immigrant parties. Societal hostility reflects the attitudes of natives living around immigrants. Because everyday contact occurs with members of that same native population, societal hostility may be more directly connected to how immigrants interpret interpersonal recognition than political hostility is. I therefore expect the relationship between contact and political integration to differ depending on whether hostility is expressed through electoral support or through native attitudes.

Using separate 2021 and 2022 German Socio-Economic Panel samples and optimal full matching, I compare immigrants who report different levels of contact with natives but share similar

¹Throughout, I use *natives* to refer to members of the dominant ethnic-majority group born in the host country without a recent migration background.

backgrounds and live in similarly hostile districts. I find that (1) immigrants who report positive interactions with natives trust institutions more than matched immigrants who do not, while immigrants who feel that others look down on them trust institutions less; (2) immigrants with mostly native friends report stronger attachment to Germany than matched immigrants with mostly migrant friends; and (3) where the AfD vote is high, immigrants with positive contact trust institutions no more than matched immigrants who do not. Where natives are very concerned about immigration, immigrants with positive contact still trust institutions more than matched immigrants who do not. But there, immigrants with mostly native friends feel less attached to Germany than matched immigrants with mostly migrant friends. Interviews with Syrian and Turkish immigrants suggest why: in hostile places, the more native friends immigrants have, the more of that rejection reaches them through people they trust.

Researchers working in the contact tradition have argued that interpersonal contact across group lines reduces prejudice and fosters cooperation under the right conditions (Allport, 1979; Pettigrew & Tropp, 2006), and a substantial recent literature has examined whether and how these effects extend to native-immigrant relations (Barth & Parry, 2009; Choi et al., 2022; Hangartner et al., 2019; McLaren, 2003). But the literature has not systematically examined whether different forms of contact, which vary in depth and duration, respond to hostility in different directions. Nathan and Sands (2023) argue that context-and-contact research has moved beyond direct tests of Allport (1979)'s prejudice-reduction framework toward a typology of contact forms varying in depth (casual to cooperative) and duration (brief to sustained). Building on this, I examine two forms of sustained contact that differ in depth: everyday interaction, whose quality I measure in Study 1 (2021 SOEP), and friendship, the deeper tie I measure in Study 2 (2022 SOEP).

This paper makes three contributions. First, it extends contact theory beyond its conventional focus on majority group prejudice reduction (Paluck et al., 2019) toward a minority-centered account of how interpersonal recognition is associated with political self-perception. Second, it distinguishes political from societal hostility. Where political hostility is high, positive everyday contact and institutional trust are no longer associated. Where societal hostility is high, that association survives; what reverses is the association between native friendship and belonging. Third, it demonstrates that the contact-integration relationship is not uniformly positive. Under high societal hostility, closer ties with natives can heighten rather than buffer immigrants' awareness of broader exclusion, pointing to a micro-level mechanism for the integration paradox (Lajevardi et al., 2020) that existing contact theory has not systematically examined.

2 Intergroup Contact to Political Integration

2.1 Contact Theory

Early literature on intergroup relations has proposed that contact across social lines can reduce prejudice when certain conditions are met: equal status between majority and minority groups, the pursuit of common goals, institutional support, and a shared perception of common interests and humanity (Allport, 1979; Alrababa'h et al., 2019). Scholars have examined the effects of contact across a wide range of intergroup settings, including religious affiliations (Scacco & Warren, 2018), race and ethnicity (Mousa, 2020), and native-immigrant dynamics (Chiswick & Wang, 2016; McLaren, 2003). Recent research, however, indicates that the effects of contact depend heavily on the nature of the interactions and the specific targets of prejudice, leading to findings that are more equivocal than earlier literature suggested (Paluck et al., 2019). While intergroup contact can positively affect behaviors, its effects on attitudes are weaker and less consistent (Scacco & Warren, 2018), suggesting that attitudes are more resistant to change than behaviors and that the conditions

under which contact reduces prejudice are more demanding than Allport originally anticipated.

Native-immigrant relations present distinctive challenges for contact theory. Unlike hierarchies based solely on race or ethnicity within an established citizenry, native-immigrant relations combine social hierarchies with contested national membership. Immigrants' belonging to the political community is not assumed but actively questioned, even after naturalization. While contact may reduce hostility under certain conditions (Berinsky et al., 2023; McLaren, 2003), other research shows that even norm-conforming immigrants face persistent bias (Choi et al., 2021; Choi et al., 2022). This underscores that positive interactions can often have only a minimal effect on reducing prejudice depending on the targets of prejudice, types of interventions and also the timing of the outcomes (Paluck et al., 2021) and that the majority's prejudice against minorities are not as easily disappeared as the contact theory would expect. In particular, when intergroup relations are shaped by ethnic hierarchies, reducing prejudice becomes especially difficult, often requiring far more than simple exposure or compliance with dominant norms.

Applying it to immigrants introduces additional complexities given the asymmetrical status between immigrants and natives: immigrants enter a preexisting social and political order where they often have fewer rights, less political voice, and limited avenues for full societal participation, even after naturalization (Jiménez et al., 2021). Contact theory posits that positive effects arise from interactions between groups of equal status, yet achieving perceived equality is particularly challenging for immigrants who perceive that natives support restrictive immigration policies targeted at their group (Pérez, 2015). Under these conditions of asymmetry and perceived hostility, contact may not produce uniformly positive effects—indeed, scholars have documented instances of an "integration paradox" where deeper integration corresponds with lower rather than higher belonging. To address this complexity, I develop a minority-centered perspective that examines how interpersonal contact is associated with immigrants' attitudes toward the host society and their place within its political community, and under what conditions contact is positively or negatively associated with political integration.

2.2 Micro-Level Contact and Macro-Level Context

Immigrants' political integration is shaped by both interpersonal contact with natives and the broader societal climate in which these interactions occur. As Prati et al. (2022) note, these two dimensions are deeply interrelated: immigrants become aware of macro-level hostility through micro-level processes such as reading news, observing political discourse, and hearing about anti-immigrant sentiment from others. However, distinguishing between them analytically is essential for understanding how they jointly shape political integration.

Micro-level contact refers to interpersonal encounters between immigrants and natives through which recognition, exclusion, or shared membership may be communicated. Macro-level context, by contrast, refers to the broader environment that structures these interactions and is associated with how they are interpreted (Nathan & Sands, 2023). Although contact and context are closely related (Barth et al., 2009), they operate through distinct mechanisms. Different contexts shape both the likelihood of cross-group interaction and the meanings attached to those interactions (Allport, 1979). Street harassment by strangers reflects ambient societal hostility, not interpersonal contact. Interpersonal contact requires ongoing relationships with identifiable individuals, such as colleagues, neighbors, or friends. The distinction is whether the experience is relational (repeated interactions) or ambient (signals from strangers, media, and political discourse).

This distinction is particularly important for immigrants. Because immigration is a politically salient issue in most Western democracies, immigrants are acutely aware of both the interpersonal signals they receive from individual natives and the broader societal signals they receive from the

political environment around them. Conflating the two risks misattributing the effects of one to the other. How macro-level context matters, moreover, runs through perception: if context shapes individual-level outcomes such as threat or belonging, it must do so via how individuals perceive their surroundings (Wong et al., 2012). Immigrants inhabiting the same objective environment may therefore read it differently, depending on their experiences, networks, and exposure to political information (Wong et al., 2025). An immigrant who experiences positive recognition from a native colleague at work but lives in a district with high levels of anti-immigrant sentiment is navigating two very different signals simultaneously, one at the micro level and one at the macro level, and these signals do not necessarily point in the same direction. Moreover, newcomers may initially find interpersonal signals easier to read than the ambient political climate; only with time does macro-level hostility become fully legible (Lajevardi et al., 2020). Disentangling these two levels of analysis is therefore not merely a methodological choice but a theoretical necessity for understanding how immigrants come to see themselves as members of the political community.

2.3 Contact to Identity Shift: Decategorization and Recategorization

Interpersonal contact with natives does not shape political integration directly. Rather, contact matters because it initiates shifts in how immigrants perceive themselves in relation to the host society, moving them from feeling like categorical outsiders to feeling like recognized members of the political community. According to social identity theory, people tend to treat individual members of an outgroup as indistinguishable representatives of a single social category (Brewer & Miller, 1984; Tajfel, 1981). Drawing on social identity theory, I argue that positive interpersonal contact can operate through two related mechanisms: *decategorization* and *recategorization* (Choi et al., 2023; Gaertner et al., 1993).

Decategorization involves reducing the emphasis on group identities, encouraging individuals to interact based on personal characteristics rather than group affiliations. In contexts where immigration is a salient issue, immigrants may experience heightened awareness of their minority status, feeling more visible or distinct within the host society (Mayorga, 2021). In such environments, immigrants may also perceive the native population as a homogeneous group, reinforcing stereotypes or assumptions in the absence of meaningful interpersonal contact. In the context of immigrant incorporation, positive contact may allow immigrants to feel seen as individuals rather than as generic outsiders. Such interactions can communicate recognition and respect, weakening the sense of categorical distance between immigrants and natives.

Recategorization, by contrast, occurs when these interactions foster a broader sense of shared membership (Gaertner et al., 1993). For individual immigrants, recategorization involves shifting their personal sense of group boundaries so they begin to see themselves as part of a larger community that includes both immigrants and natives (Dovidio & Gaertner, 2000; Verwey, n.d.). Through positive interpersonal contact, immigrants can learn to identify not only with their subgroup but also with the broader community. When these interactions are based on mutual respect, immigrants can feel recognized as equal participants in the political and social life of the host society (Simon & Schaefer, 2016). Together, decategorization and recategorization describe a gradual process through which interpersonal contact moves immigrants beyond outsider status toward fuller psychological inclusion within the political community (Simon & Schaefer, 2016).

The identity shift carries political weight because of who the relevant out-group is. In the classic contact theory, reconciled groups develop warmer feelings toward one another, but they do not necessarily develop attachment to any larger institutions that include both groups. The Rattlers and the Eagles came to like each other (Sherif, 1988), but they had no special reason to feel loyal to the camp. However, native-immigrant contact is different. Natives are not merely another so-

cial group whose esteem matters to immigrants. They are constitutive members of the political community, the group whose membership defines what it means to belong to the state in the first place. When recategorization moves an immigrant from seeing natives as a distinct out-group to seeing them as part of a shared "we", that shift is not only social. It changes who the immigrant understands themselves to be in relation to the host country as a political community. Becoming, in a meaningful sense, part of the same community as natives means becoming part of the community whose institutions, elections, and rules of public life govern the immigrant's own life. Where hostility threatens immigrants' standing as legitimate members, being treated as an equal by natives can also restore a sense of dignity that ambient exclusion erodes (Honneth, 1996). This is why decategorization and recategorization, mechanisms that social psychology developed to explain intergroup liking, can plausibly translate into specifically political outcomes for immigrants.

2.3.1 Quality of Contact: Positive and Negative Interaction

Whether an interaction is positive or negative reflects different signals about immigrants' standing in the host society. Positive interaction includes experiences of appreciation, respect, and acknowledgment, which can signal to immigrants that they are valued members of society (Honneth, 1996). Such affirming interactions foster feelings of inclusion, making immigrants more likely to trust political institutions and feel capable of political engagement. Positive contact is the active presence of respect and recognition that nurtures psychological integration. By contrast, negative encounters, such as discrimination, exclusion, or perceived misrecognition, can reinforce group boundaries, deepen feelings of alienation, and undermine immigrants' belief that they are legitimate participants in political life. Recent research highlights that negative interpersonal contact may have an even stronger impact than positive contact on shaping intergroup outcomes (Barlow et al., 2012). Scholars have increasingly emphasized the need to examine both positive and negative contact simultaneously, recognizing that real-world interactions often involve a mix of both experiences (Graf et al., 2014; Prati et al., 2022). This leads me to the first hypothesis:

- *H1a Immigrants with more positive contact with natives will have higher level of political integration.*
- *H1b Immigrants with more negative contact with natives will have lower level of political integration.*

2.3.2 Depth of Contact: Strong and Weak Ties

The political consequences of contact may also vary by the depth of the relationship. Routine interactions with natives in everyday settings may provide useful exposure and information, but stronger and more socially embedded ties are likely to be more consequential. Friendships, in particular, involve repeated, reciprocal, and personally meaningful interaction, making them a more durable source of recognition and support than weaker forms of contact (Davies et al., 2011; Zhou et al., 2019). While everyday interactions may initiate decategorization, it is through deeper ties that recategorization is most likely to occur: sustained friendship with natives creates the conditions for immigrants to develop a genuine sense of shared membership rather than merely reduced categorical distance. Belonging, rather than trust or efficacy, is the outcome most directly implicated here because it captures the emotional and identificational dimensions of political integration, the sense of being part of a community, which friendship ties are uniquely positioned to foster. This leads to the following hypothesis:

- *H2 Immigrants with more native friends will have higher level of political integration.*

2.4 Contextual Hostility and the Asymmetry of Contact

I distinguish between two forms of contextual hostility: societal hostility, which captures the prevailing attitudinal climate toward immigrants in everyday social contexts, and political hostility, which reflects the extent to which anti-immigrant sentiment is expressed through electoral behavior. Although related, these two forms of hostility operate in different channels and may condition the effects of interpersonal contact differently.

Societal hostility refers to the prevailing attitudinal climate toward immigrants in everyday social life within a locality. It is mainly about natives' privately held views, expressed in conversation, posture, and ordinary social conduct rather than in organized political action. For an immigrant, societal hostility is encountered ambiently and incrementally, through the looks, comments, and small acts of inclusion or exclusion that accumulate over many encounters. *Political hostility*, by contrast, refers to the visible, organized expression of anti-immigrant sentiment in the public political arena. It is not in private attitudes but in the institutional channels through which collective decisions are made and publicly contested, such as electoral support for parties that mobilize on immigration or organized political activity. What makes hostility political is that it is no longer a private disposition but a publicly legitimate position around which collective action is organized. For an immigrant, political hostility is encountered as public information about what is sayable, supportable, and politically consequential.

This distinction extends to research on perceived discrimination that has drawn context at the individual level: minorities respond differently to unfair treatment from political institutions (political discrimination) than to interpersonal rejection (societal discrimination) (Oskooii, 2020; Oskooii, 2016). Whereas the work captures "discrimination" as individuals perceive and report it, I measure the "hostility" of the surrounding environment directly, capturing signals that reach immigrants regardless of whether they have personally experienced mistreatment. If the source of perceived mistreatment conditions its behavioral consequences, the form that contextual hostility takes should likewise condition how interpersonal contact is interpreted, which is why the two measures are likely to interact with intergroup contact in different ways.

The relationship between contact and political integration need not be uniform across contexts, but existing theory does not provide clear guidance about the direction of contextual moderation. Two competing theoretical perspectives suggest different possibilities. The first perspective suggests that hostility should weaken or nullify the positive effects of interpersonal contact. In highly hostile environments, immigrants may interpret even positive interactions with natives as exceptions rather than as signals of broader acceptance, limiting contact's capacity to promote political integration. Moreover, the psychological salience of macro-level exclusion may overwhelm the integrative potential of micro-level recognition. Research on how local demographics shape attitudes shows that macro-level political rhetoric can activate, suppress, or even reverse the effects of local demographic contexts (Hopkins, 2010). When hostile national or local political climates dominate public discourse, individual positive interactions may be depoliticized or dismissed as unrepresentative, whereas macro-level exclusion becomes the primary frame through which immigrants interpret their place in the host society. Negative contact, conversely, may become less influential under high hostility simply because it is more common and thus less informative: when discrimination is pervasive, individual experiences of misrecognition add little new information about one's standing in the host society. From this perspective, contextual hostility should attenuate the relationship between contact quality and political integration. This argument aligns with contact theory's emphasis that in order for contact to produce meaningful outcomes, the broader social environment must support rather than undermine intergroup interaction (Allport, 1979; Pettigrew & Tropp, 2006). When contextual hostility pervades the environment, positive individual

encounters occur against a backdrop of societal-level rejection, limiting their capacity to reshape immigrants' perceptions of their standing in the political community.

An alternative perspective suggests that hostility may amplify rather than suppress the effects of interpersonal contact. Under high societal hostility, positive interactions with natives may carry extra weight precisely because they are rare and thus especially informative. When the surrounding environment signals exclusion, a single affirming interaction communicates recognition in direct contradiction to the ambient hostility, functioning as a counter-signal that sustains political trust even where the broader climate is unwelcoming. Because immigrants often lack the linguistic and cultural familiarity to immediately interpret subtle forms of societal hostility (Lajevardi et al., 2020), they may initially rely more heavily on direct interpersonal contact as a signal of their place in the host society, making affirming interactions especially consequential under hostile conditions. Conversely, negative contact may become more harmful under high hostility, as experiences of misrecognition reinforce rather than contradict the broader climate of exclusion. From this perspective, contextual hostility should amplify the relationship between contact quality and political integration, making both positive and negative interactions more rather than less consequential.

These competing perspectives lead to contrasting empirical predictions. The first perspective predicts that as hostility increases, the associations between contact and political integration should weaken and approach zero. The second perspective predicts that as hostility increases, these associations should strengthen, with positive contact showing larger positive effects and negative contact showing larger negative effects. Immigrants navigate political contexts where their group identity is publicly contested, and this can moderate how their preferences translate into political behavior (Lee & Kim-Leffingwell, 2025). A similar dynamic may operate at the attitudinal level: in hostile contexts, the gap between personal acceptance and group-level rejection becomes psychologically salient, conditioning how interpersonal contact is interpreted. I test these competing predictions with the following hypotheses:

- *H3a Higher levels of contextual hostility weaken the association between contact and political integration.*
- *H3b Higher levels of contextual hostility strengthen the association between contact and political integration.*

3 Studies

I use a mixed-methods approach to examine how interpersonal contact with natives is associated with immigrant political integration across hostile contexts. Studies 1 and 2 use survey data from the German Socio-Economic Panel to examine the quality and depth of contact, while Study 3 draws on in-depth interviews with immigrants in Germany to assess the proposed mechanisms.

Germany provides a useful setting because hostility toward immigrants varies substantially across regions. Support for the Alternative for Germany (AfD) is especially strong in eastern Germany, creating meaningful local variation in political hostility and allowing me to examine whether interpersonal contact operates differently across more and less hostile contexts.²

Data: German Socio-Economic Panel 2021 and 2022 The SOEP is a nationally representative longitudinal survey of private households in Germany. I use two waves that capture different di-

²I focus on Germany in this paper for analytical depth, but the broader theoretical framework is not Germany-specific. In other chapters of my dissertation, I extend the analysis to Belgium, where the political and reception contexts for recent immigrants differ, allowing me to assess the generalizability of the mechanisms developed here.

mensions of intergroup contact. The 2021 wave includes detailed measures capturing immigrants' everyday experiences of recognition and misrecognition in interactions with others. The 2022 wave includes measures of friendship networks with native Germans, capturing stronger interpersonal ties. While both waves draw from the same survey infrastructure, they capture different dimensions of intergroup contact (Table A1)³. I focus on post-1995 arrivals, for whom sustained interpersonal contact with natives across everyday settings is relatively and more structurally possible. The guest-worker-era cohorts of the 1960s and 1970s faced different opportunity structures for contact that fall outside the scope of this study.

Contextual Measures of Hostility To incorporate the broader environment in which interpersonal contact occurs, I construct contextual measures of anti-immigrant hostility at the regional level. Because SOEP contains restricted geographic identifiers, these contextual variables are linked to respondents at the Kreis (district) level using the restricted-access SOEP data available through the SOEP Research Data Center at DIW Berlin. I distinguish between two forms of contextual hostility: political hostility and societal hostility. Administrative units do not necessarily correspond to the communities immigrants perceive themselves to inhabit. However, research comparing administrative aggregates with more personalized measures of context, including self-drawn community boundaries, finds that administrative measures often align more closely with residents' perceptions of their local environment (Velez & Wong, 2017). One reason may be that people learn about the broader context not only through direct encounters, but also through local media, social networks, and visible political activity (Huckfeldt, 2014; Velez & Wong, 2017).

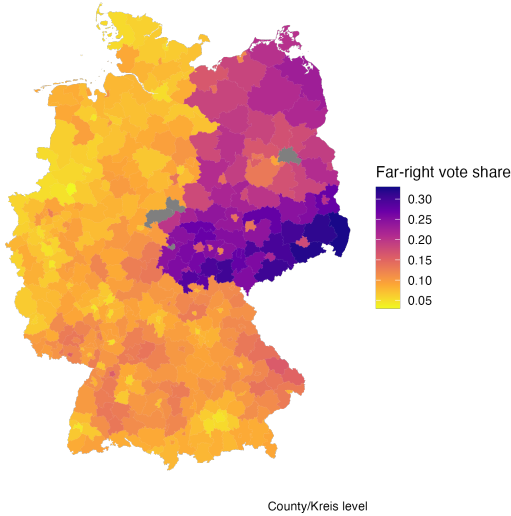
I operationalize **political hostility** using electoral support for the Alternative for Germany (AfD), measured as district-level vote share in the 2021 federal election and obtained from the German Election Database (GERDA) (Heddesheimer et al., 2025). Founded in 2013 as a Euro-sceptic party, the AfD transformed during the 2015 refugee crisis into a radical-right party for which opposition to immigration became a central programmatic position (Arzheimer & Berning, 2019). AfD support captures more than the preferences of its own voters: radical-right electoral success causally shifts mainstream parties' positions on immigration in a restrictive direction (Abou-Chadi & Krause, 2020), so district-level AfD strength indexes the broader anti-immigrant tilt of the local political arena rather than the stance of a single party. I use vote share rather than electoral victory because even where the AfD does not win pluralities, its electoral presence signals that anti-immigrant positions are publicly legitimate and politically consequential in that locality (Heddesheimer et al., 2024).

Societal hostility is measured by aggregating native-born SOEP respondents' answers to the question, *"How concerned are you about immigration in Germany?"* (0 = "not at all concerned," 2 = "very concerned"). I compute the average level of concern among native respondents within each Kreis to capture the prevailing attitudinal climate toward immigrants and link this measure to immigrant respondents living in the same district (Figure 1).⁴

³A detailed description of the SOEP dataset, including wave-specific samples and questionnaire content, is provided in Appendix B.

⁴The two measures correlate at $r = 0.65$ at the Kreis level, indicating that political and societal hostility tend to co-occur in the same localities. The correlation is strong enough to validate construct overlap, but not so high as to suggest redundancy.

Political Hostility (GERDA)



Societal Hostility (SOEP)

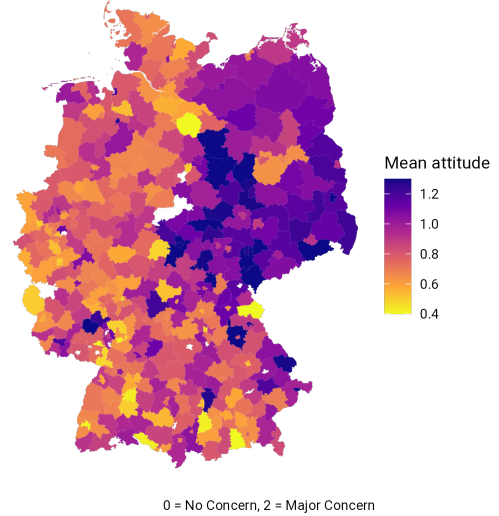


Figure 1: District-level measures of societal and political hostility in Germany

3.1 Study 1: Quality of Everyday Interactions and Political Integration

Among the 2,207 immigrants surveyed in 2021, the analytical sample consists of respondents who reported interactions in native-majority settings. Descriptive statistics for the respondents included in the 2021 sample are reported in the Appendix C.

3.1.1 Measures

Explanatory variables: quality of interaction *Positive interactions* capture experiences in which immigrants feel recognized or valued in their everyday encounters with others. I measure positive interaction using two survey items that ask respondents how often they experience appreciation from others. The items are: (1) “I feel like other people appreciate what I do” and (2) “I feel like other people look up to me.” Responses range from 1 (never) to 7 (frequently). I combine these two items into an additive index ranging from 2 to 14, where higher values indicate more frequent experiences of appreciation. Respondents were then asked: “Now, if you think back to situations where you have felt like others did appreciate what you were doing or that others looked up to you: Where specifically have you had these kinds of experiences?” Response options included workplace, government agencies, on the street, in the family, among friends, leisure time, social media, and other contexts.

Negative interactions capture experiences in which immigrants feel devalued or disrespected in their everyday encounters. This measure is based on two survey items: (1) “I feel like other people do not appreciate what I do” and (2) “I feel like other people look down on me.” Responses again range from 1 (never) to 7 (frequently). These items are also combined into an additive index. Same as positive interactions, respondents were then asked about the settings where they had these experiences. To better capture interactions with natives, I restrict the analysis to respondents who reported these experiences in native-majority settings and exclude those who reported them only within family or friendship contexts.⁵

⁵While these items capture subjective experiences, several features suggest they measure interaction quality rather than stable personality traits. The two positive items correlate at $r = 0.51$ and the two negative items at $r = 0.58$, in-

Outcome Measures *Political trust* is measured on a 0-10 scale across five items (parliament, legal system, police, politicians, parties), divided into institutional trust (parliament, legal system, police) and trust in political actors (politicians, parties). *Political efficacy* measures respondents' perceived ability to understand and engage with politics. This measure is constructed using two survey items: (1) "How often does politics seem so complicated that you do not really understand what it is about?" and (2) "How difficult is it for you to form an opinion on political issues?" Responses range from 1 ("very often") to 5 ("never"), with higher values indicating greater internal political efficacy. *Political interest* measures respondents' level of interest in political affairs. Respondents are asked "How interested are you in politics?" with responses ranging from 0 ("not seriously at all") to 3 ("very seriously").

Covariates I adjust for individual characteristics that plausibly predict both contact with natives and political integration: age, gender, years since migration, EU origin, whether the immigrant arrived recently or is long-established, German citizenship, education, German language proficiency, and logged household income, along with residence in West Germany and the proportion of foreigners in the region. I also adjust for the other dimension of contact, that is, negative contact in the positive-contact models and positive contact in the negative-contact models. These characteristics capture an immigrant's exposure to and resources within the host society, which shape both the opportunity for native contact and the capacity for political engagement. Contextual hostility measures (district-level AfD vote share and aggregated native attitudes toward immigration) are described in the overview section above.

3.1.2 Analytical Sample Construction

After restricting the sample to interactions reported in native-majority settings, the analytical sample consists of 1,295 observations for positive interactions and 1,101 observations for negative interactions. To form high- and low-contact groups for the matching analysis, I split each contact index at its median: at 9 for positive contact and at 6 for negative contact. Respondents scoring above the median are coded as high contact and those at or below it as low contact. I use the median rather than the mean because both indices are skewed, with positive contact concentrated toward the high end and negative contact toward the low end (Figure A2, Appendix D.1).

3.1.3 Methods

Estimating the association between everyday contact and political integration is complicated by the fact that immigrants who experience frequent positive contact with natives are not a random subset of immigrants. They tend to have lived in Germany longer, speak German more fluently, hold citizenship more often, and live in districts where natives are, on average, more receptive and welcoming to immigration. Each of these characteristics can raise the level of political integration of immigrants, so a simple comparison of high- and low-contact immigrants would conflate the

dicating internal consistency. However, positive and negative interactions are nearly uncorrelated (r ranges from -0.15 to -0.00), indicating they capture distinct experiences. The follow-up question about interaction settings also reveals substantial within-person variation: the same respondent may report appreciation in one context (e.g., workplace) but misrecognition in another (e.g., government agencies), suggesting the measures are sensitive to situational differences. Factor analyses of these interaction settings confirm that positive interactions cluster into relational/private contexts versus public/institutional contexts, while negative interactions show a more complex three-factor structure (see Appendix D, Tables A4 and A5). Qualitative interviews with immigrants in Germany further validate this interpretation, as respondents consistently described experiences of recognition and misrecognition as situationally specific rather than reflective of a general disposition.

relationship of interest (contact and political integration) with the conditions that make contact more likely in the first place. The same logic applies to negative contact.

An ideal design would compare the same immigrant under two otherwise identical versions of daily life: one in which they experience frequent positive contact with natives and another in which they do not. Because such counterfactual comparisons are impossible to observe directly, I instead construct matched sets of immigrants who are alike on the background characteristics that shape both who has contact and how integrated they are, and who live in districts with similar levels of contextual hostility. Within each matched set, immigrants differ in their reported contact, but not, on average, in the background or contextual conditions that surround it. Differences in political integration within these sets can then be more plausibly read as reflecting contact rather than the factors that make contact more or less likely.

I include each hostility measure as a continuous covariate in the propensity score and the Mahalanobis distance, so that immigrants in the same matched set live in districts with similar levels of either political hostility (district-level AfD support) or societal hostility (aggregated native attitudes). I construct two parallel matched samples for each exposure, one for each hostility measure, which lets me later examine how the contact–integration association shifts across the full distribution of contextual hostility rather than collapsing it into discrete categories at the design stage. Because I analyze positive and negative interactions as separate exposures, and because hostility is measured using two contextual indicators, I construct four separate matched samples:

1. **Positive contact, matched on political hostility:** Exposed = high positive contact (appreciation index > 9), Unexposed = low positive contact (index ≤ 9). Matched sets hold district-level AfD support similar.
2. **Positive contact, matched on societal hostility:** Same exposure contrast as (1), but matched sets instead hold aggregated native attitudes similar.
3. **Negative contact, matched on political hostility:** Exposed = high negative contact (misrecognition index > 6), Unexposed = low negative contact (index ≤ 6). Matched sets hold AfD support similar.
4. **Negative contact, matched on societal hostility:** Same exposure contrast as (3), but matched sets instead hold native attitudes similar.

For each sample, I estimate a propensity score by logistic regression of the exposure on the potential confounders listed above, the missingness indicators, and the relevant hostility measure (district-level AfD support or aggregated native attitudes). From this model I form two distances between exposed and unexposed immigrants: the difference in the estimated propensity score, and a rank-based Mahalanobis distance over the same covariates. I then group immigrants into matched sets by optimal full matching on the propensity-score distance, implemented in `optmatch` (Hansen, 2004; Hansen & Klopfer, 2006), restricting allowable matches to pairs within a caliper on both the propensity-score distance and the Mahalanobis distance. I choose the caliper widths and the permitted range of set sizes by searching over candidate values and keeping the specification that yields the best covariate balance at the largest effective sample size.

I assess balance with the omnibus and covariate-specific statistics in `RIttools` (Hansen & Bowers, 2008). After matching, every covariate differs by less than 0.1 standardized units between exposed and unexposed immigrants, and the omnibus test does not reject balance. Contextual hostility is among the balanced covariates: within matched sets, exposed and unexposed immigrants live in districts with nearly identical levels of AfD support or native hostility (standardized differences

well below 0.1 in every sample). Matching therefore holds contextual hostility close to constant within sets, which is what later allows me to examine how the contact association varies across the full range of hostility rather than at a single level. Balance diagnostics for all four samples are reported in Appendix E (Tables A6, A7, A8, A9).

Within the matched samples I estimate two quantities. The first is the average within-set difference in political integration between exposed and unexposed immigrants:

$$Y_i = \alpha_{s(i)} + \beta_1 \text{Contact}_i + \varepsilon_i, \quad (1)$$

where Y_i is one integration outcome (trust in institutions or in political actors, efficacy, or interest) and $\alpha_{s(i)}$ is a fixed effect for the matched set s containing immigrant i . The matched-set fixed effects confine each comparison to immigrants in the same set, who are alike on the confounders and on contextual hostility, so β_1 is an adjusted difference between exposure groups, averaged across the full distribution of contextual hostility, rather than a causal effect.

The second quantity asks whether that difference depends on contextual hostility. I add hostility and its interaction with contact:

$$Y_i = \alpha_{s(i)} + \beta_1 \text{Contact}_i + \beta_2 \text{Hostility}_i + \beta_3 (\text{Contact}_i \times \text{Hostility}_i) + \varepsilon_i. \quad (2)$$

I cluster standard errors at the district (Kreis) level using the CR2 correction (Pustejovsky & Tipton, 2018), implemented in *estimatr*. To interpret the interaction, I report predicted outcomes at the 30th, 50th, and 70th percentiles of the within-sample hostility distribution (Figures 3 and 4).

3.1.4 Results

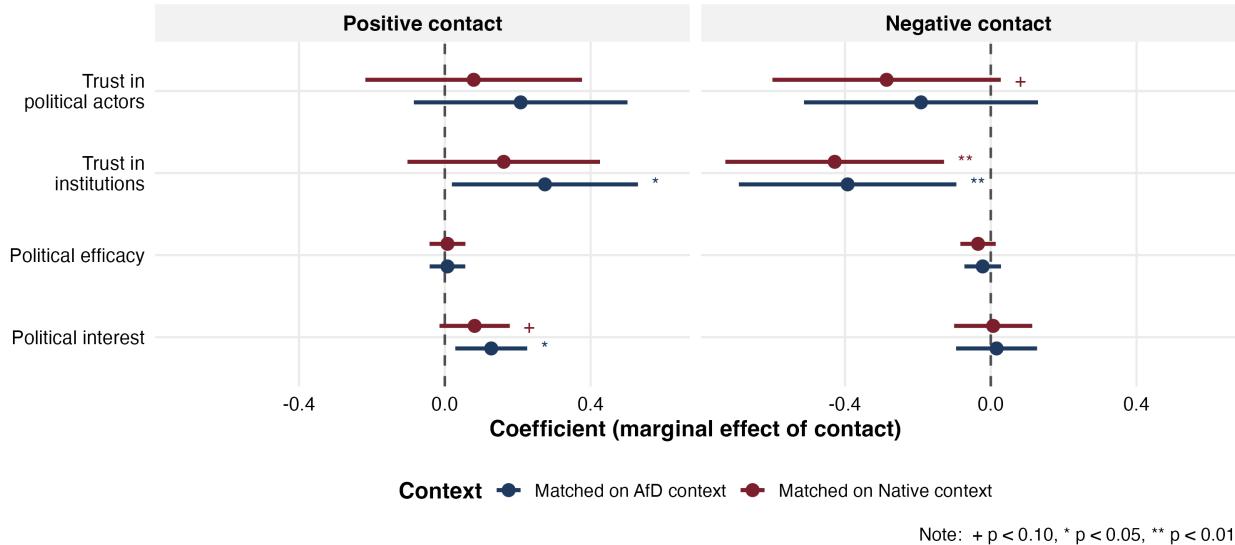


Figure 2: Quality of Everyday Contact with Natives and Political Integration

Note: Point estimates and 95% confidence intervals from optimal full matching analysis. Left panel shows positive contact (N = 1,295); right panel shows negative contact (N = 1,101). “Matched on AfD context” uses district-level AfD vote share; “Matched on Native context” uses aggregated native attitudes toward immigration. All models include matched-set fixed effects with standard errors clustered at the Kreis level.

Figure 2 presents the baseline association between everyday contact with natives and political integration among first-generation immigrants in Germany, estimated using optimal full matching on observable characteristics. Results from the positive contact models (left panel) show that immigrants who report frequent positive interactions with natives express higher institutional trust and greater political interest than otherwise similar immigrants who do not. Point estimates are positive across all four outcomes, with the clearest and most consistent patterns for trust in political institutions and political interest. Trust in institutions is significantly higher in the model matched on AfD support, while political interest is significantly higher across both contextual specifications. Political efficacy and trust in political actors show weaker and less certain patterns, suggesting that everyday contact does not relate equally to all dimensions of political integration. These results provide partial support for H1a.

In contrast, negative interactions show a stronger and more consistent relationship with trust in institutions. Immigrants who report experiences of misrecognition express significantly lower levels of trust in political institutions across both contextual specifications. Negative interactions, however, show little association with political interest or internal political efficacy. This partially supports H1b.

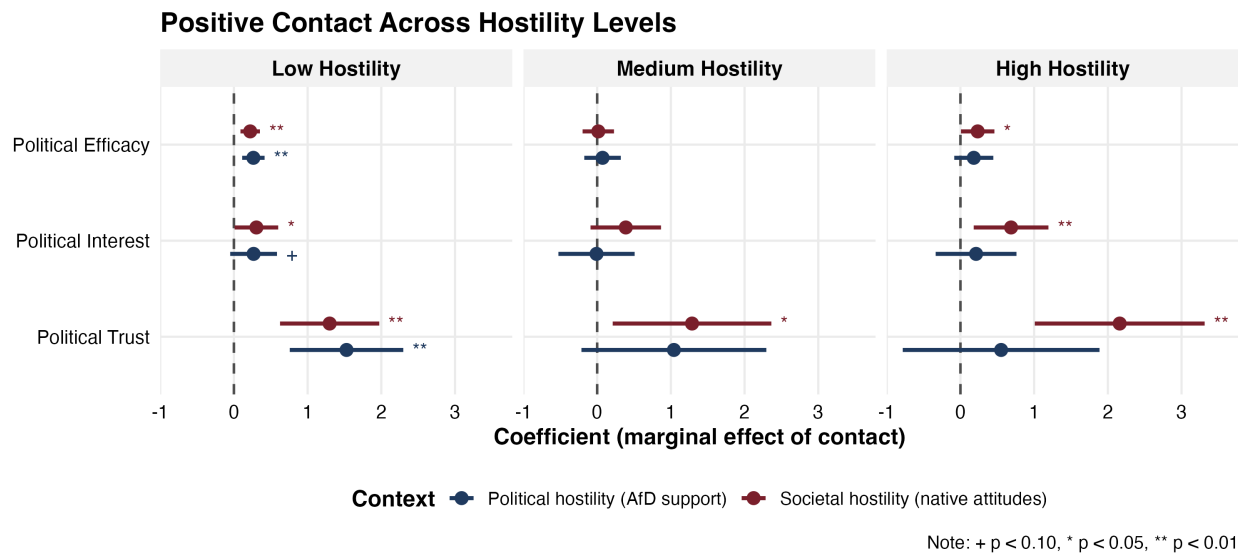


Figure 3: Positive Contact and Political Integration Across Levels of Hostility

Note: Marginal effects of positive contact on political integration across low, medium, and high levels of hostility (30th, 50th, and 70th percentiles). Blue points show effects under political hostility (AfD support); red points show effects under societal hostility (native attitudes toward immigration). Estimates from interaction models with matched-set fixed effects. Standard errors clustered at Kreis level. + $p < 0.10$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$.

Contact and Political Integration in Low Hostility Contexts While the baseline models hold contextual hostility similar within matched sets, they average the contact and integration association across all levels of hostility. To understand whether this association itself varies with the surrounding climate, Figures 3 and 4 show the marginal association between the quality of contact and political integration at low, medium, and high levels of contextual hostility.

The clearest patterns appear in low-hostility districts. Where AfD support is low or native concern about immigration is minimal, immigrants who report frequent positive contact express

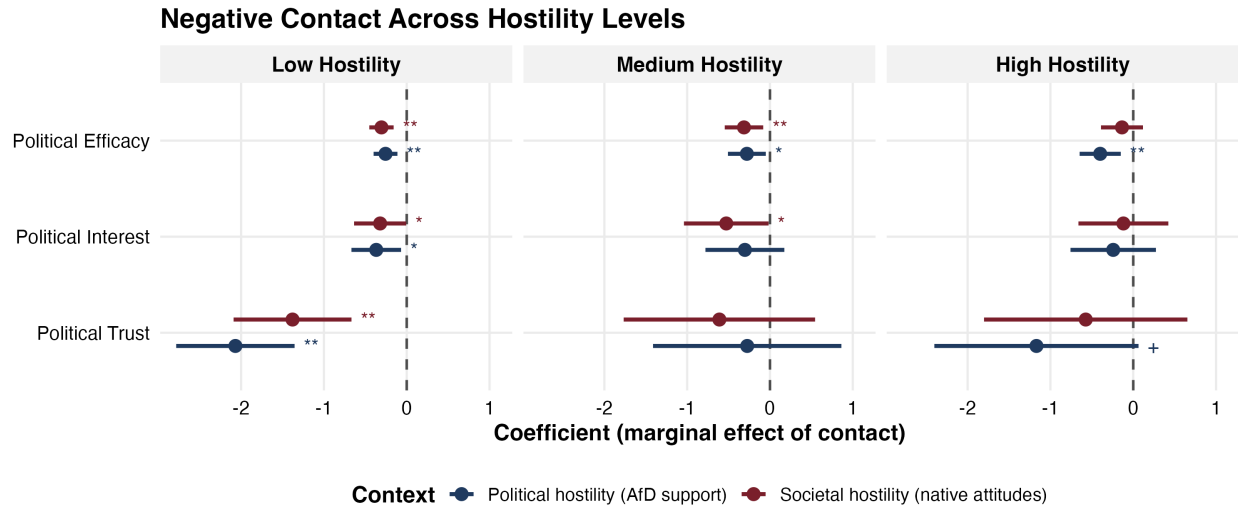


Figure 4: Negative Contact and Political Integration Across Levels of Hostility
Note: Marginal effects of negative contact on political integration across low, medium, and high levels of hostility (30th, 50th, and 70th percentiles). Blue points show effects under political hostility (AfD support); red points show effects under societal hostility (native attitudes toward immigration). Estimates from interaction models with matched-set fixed effects. Standard errors clustered at Kreis level. + $p < 0.10$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$.

higher political trust, greater political interest, and stronger political efficacy than otherwise similar immigrants, while those who report misrecognition express lower levels on all three (Figures 3 and 4, leftmost panels). These low-hostility estimates support H1a and H1b.

This pattern suggests that hostility does not simply strengthen or weaken the relationship between contact and political integration. For positive contact, the two forms of hostility produce different patterns. As societal hostility rises, positive contact is more strongly related to political trust and political interest. Under political hostility, by contrast, the trust association weakens and is no longer distinguishable from zero where AfD support is high. These results support H3b under societal hostility and H3a under political hostility.

Negative contact shows a different pattern. Its relationship with trust and interest is generally clearest in low-hostility districts and becomes less consistent as hostility rises, suggesting that experiences of misrecognition may be more informative when they are less expected. The negative relationship between misrecognition and efficacy, however, remains relatively consistent across levels of political hostility. Overall, contextual hostility shapes the relationship between contact and political integration differently depending on how hostility is expressed and which dimension of political integration is considered.

The results are not sensitive to the choice of cutoff. I re-estimate all models using cutoffs one point above and one point below the median in matched samples constructed without the restricted district-level variables. The association with institutional trust remains positive and statistically significant across all specifications, and the estimate under the main cutoff is among the smaller estimates. By contrast, the association with political interest weakens under the alternative cutoffs and should therefore be interpreted as suggestive. Full results are reported in Appendix A13.

3.2 Study 2: Friendship Ties and a Sense of Belonging

While Study 1 examines the quality of everyday interactions, Study 2 examines the depth of contact through friendship ties with natives. Friendships represent deeper, more sustained contact involving repeated, reciprocal, and personally meaningful engagement. The 2022 survey includes 4,480 respondents (demographics in Appendix C).

3.2.1 Measures

The **explanatory variable**, friendship with natives, asks respondents "How many of your friends are not from Germany or have parents who are not from Germany, in other words, have a migration background?" Responses range from 1 (all friends have migration background) to 6 (all friends are German). The **outcome variable**, sense of belonging, asks "how emotionally attached do you feel to Germany?" with answers from 0 to 10 (Figure A1). **Covariates** include age, gender, years since migration, EU origin, refugee background, citizenship, education, logged income, residence in West Germany, and the proportion of foreigners in the district. Contextual hostility measures are described in the overview above.

3.2.2 Methods

I recode the friendship variable into a binary exposure: respondents who selected 1 or 2 are classified as having predominantly migrant friends (unexposed), while those who selected 5 or 6 are classified as having predominantly native friends (exposed). Respondents who selected 3 or 4 are excluded, as their friendship composition is mixed.⁶ After this restriction, the analytical sample consists of 4,462 observations.

The analytical approach follows Study 1. For each hostility measure, I estimate a propensity score by logistic regression of the exposure on the covariates, the missingness indicators, and the relevant hostility measure, and I form a propensity-score distance and a rank-based Mahalanobis distance over the same covariates. I then group immigrants into matched sets by optimal full matching on the propensity-score distance (Hansen, 2004; Hansen & Klopfer, 2006), restricting matches to immigrants within a caliper on both distances, so that within each matched set immigrants live in districts with similar levels of either political or societal hostility. Matching achieves close balance in both specifications: every covariate differs by less than 0.1 standardized units between exposed and unexposed immigrants, and the omnibus test does not reject balance (Hansen & Bowers, 2008) ($p > 0.99$ in both cases). Full diagnostics are reported in Appendix Tables A10 and A11.

After constructing the matched samples, I estimate the average within-set difference in sense of belonging between exposed and unexposed immigrants:

$$Y_i = \alpha_{s(i)} + \beta_1 \text{Friendship}_i + \varepsilon_i, \quad (3)$$

where Y_i is sense of belonging and $\alpha_{s(i)}$ is a fixed effect for the matched set s containing immigrant i . I cluster standard errors at the district (Kreis) level using the CR2 correction (Pustejovsky & Tipton, 2018), implemented in `estimat`. To examine whether the relationship varies across hostile contexts, I then estimate interaction models between friendship and contextual hostility, as in Study 1.

$$Y_i = \alpha_{s(i)} + \beta_1 \text{Friendship}_i + \beta_2 \text{Hostility}_i + \beta_3 (\text{Friendship}_i \times \text{Hostility}_i) + \varepsilon_i. \quad (4)$$

⁶As a robustness check, I estimated models using the full sample with friendship as continuous. The baseline association is consistent with main results.

3.2.3 Results

Across both matching specifications, immigrants with predominantly native friends report a stronger sense of belonging than those with predominantly migrant friends (Table 1). This supports H2 and suggests that deeper social ties with natives do matter for how immigrants feel they belong to the host society. However, as the interaction models below show, this baseline difference masks important variation across hostile contexts.

Table 1: Association Between Friendship and a Sense of Belonging (2022)

Context	Effect of Friendship	Std. Error	95% CI
Matched on Political Hostility	0.275	0.095	[0.088, 0.462]
Matched on Societal Hostility	0.231	0.093	[0.048, 0.413]

Note: Average within-matched-set differences in belonging between immigrants with predominantly native friends (5–6 on the 6-point scale) and those with predominantly migrant friends (1–2). Both models use the same matched sample (N = 4,462) but different contextual hostility measures. “Political Hostility” uses district-level AfD vote share; “Societal Hostility” uses aggregated native attitudes toward immigration. All models include matched-set fixed effects with standard errors clustered at the Kreis level.

To understand whether this relationship varies by context, Table 2 presents the interaction between friendship and hostility. In districts where natives are relatively welcoming, immigrants with predominantly native friends report a stronger sense of belonging than those with predominantly migrant friends. As societal hostility increases, however, this association weakens and crosses zero when average native concern about immigration reaches approximately 0.93. Above this level, the relationship becomes negative: immigrants whose friends are mostly German report a weaker sense of belonging than those whose friends are mostly other migrants. Political hostility produces a similar directional pattern, but the interaction is not statistically significant, suggesting that the reversal is more closely tied to the local attitudinal climate than to electoral support for the radical right.⁷

Table 2: Friends with Natives, Contextual Hostility, and Belonging

Predictor	M1: Political Hostility	M2: Societal Hostility
Friends with Natives	0.466	1.218**
Hostility	3.900*	1.144**
Friends X Hostility	-2.235	-1.305**
N	4462	4462
R ²	0.205	0.205

Note: OLS regression with matched-set fixed effects. For hostility measures, M1 uses district-level AfD vote share; M2 uses aggregated native concern about immigration. Both models use the same matched sample (N = 4,462). Standard errors clustered at the Kreis level. * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001.

One possible reason for this finding is that in hostile contexts, friendships with natives may make immigrants more aware of the broader hostility around them, which is a dynamic consistent with the integration paradox, whereby deeper integration exposes immigrants more directly to the

⁷The robustness check also shows that this baseline association does not depend on excluding respondents with mixed friendship networks: when they are included under a broader exposure definition, the estimate is smaller but remains positive and significant (Table A13).

gap between personal acceptance and societal rejection. When the societal environment signals exclusion at the macro level, personal ties with natives may expose immigrants more directly to that gap between their personal relationships and the broader societal climate, which could lower their sense of belonging. Together, the findings offer support for H2 in welcoming contexts, but also point to an important limit. Friendship ties with natives foster belonging when the surrounding environment is relatively open, but this relationship breaks down and even reverses in more hostile settings. This sets up a broader question about what can sustain immigrants' sense of belonging when both the societal climate and interpersonal ties fall short.

3.3 Cross-Study Analyses

Studies 1 and 2 examine two forms of interpersonal contact that differ mainly in depth. Everyday interactions are most clearly related to political trust and interest, while friendship with natives are more closely related to a sense of belonging.

Political and societal hostility produce different patterns. In Study 1, higher political hostility weakens the relationship between positive contact and institutional trust but strengthens its relationship with political interest. One possible interpretation is that the electoral success of an anti-immigrant party reduces the extent to which positive interpersonal experiences translate into confidence in political institutions, while making politics itself more personally salient. Societal hostility, by contrast, appears to shape how immigrants interpret their interpersonal relationships within the broader social environment. Experiences of recognition and misrecognition may carry different weight depending on whether the surrounding attitudinal climate generally signals acceptance or exclusion.

The clearest evidence of this appears in Study 2. Native friendships are linked to stronger belonging in relatively welcoming districts, but this relationship weakens and eventually reverses as societal hostility rises. Immigrants with predominantly native friends may therefore become especially aware of the contrast between acceptance within their personal relationships and rejection in the wider community. Rather than shielding immigrants from hostility, close ties with natives may make this contrast more visible. This pattern offers a possible micro-level explanation for the integration paradox: deeper social incorporation can coincide with weaker belonging because it increases immigrants' exposure to, and awareness of, the boundaries of their acceptance. Although the two hostility measures are correlated at $r = 0.65$, their different patterns suggest that they capture distinct signals rather than interchangeable features of the same environment.

The cross-study findings therefore point to a broader argument. Micro-level contact and macro-level context do not simply contribute independently to political integration. Context shapes what interpersonal relationships communicate, and this process varies across forms of contact and dimensions of integration. Study 3 examines whether immigrants themselves describe these distinctions and whether recognition, identity shifts, and heightened awareness of exclusion provide plausible mechanisms for the quantitative patterns.

3.4 Study 3: In-Depth Interviews

Studies 1 and 2 establish that the quality and depth of interpersonal contact with native Germans are associated with immigrants' political integration, but they cannot speak directly to the psychological processes through which this occurs. Do affirming interactions with natives actually shift how immigrants perceive themselves in relation to the political community, moving them from feeling like outsiders to feeling like legitimate members? And do immigrants themselves draw the conceptual distinction between micro-level interpersonal contact and the macro-level so-

cietal climate that my theoretical framework assumes? Study 3 addresses these questions through 18 semi-structured interviews with recent Syrian and Turkish immigrants conducted in Germany between April and May 2025. The goal is not generalizability but construct validity: to show that the contact-context distinction, the recognition versus misrecognition valence, and the identity-shift mechanisms of decategorization and recategorization are not merely analytical constructs but reflect how immigrants themselves understand and narrate their political integration.

I focus on Turkish and Syrian immigrants because they represent two distinct migration trajectories that allow me to examine the contact and context mechanisms under different starting conditions. Turkish migration to Germany dates to the guest-worker era of the 1960s, and recent Turkish arrivals enter into a dense and long-established co-ethnic infrastructure of organizations, businesses, and social networks. Syrian arrivals, concentrated after 2015, came primarily through asylum channels and lacked comparable pre-existing infrastructure. These groups are not equivalent cases, and I do not treat them as such. The asymmetry is analytically useful: if contact and contextual hostility shape political integration in similar ways across both groups, the mechanisms are not artifacts of one migration pathway. Where the groups diverge, the divergence helps locate the conditions under which the mechanisms operate. Throughout the analysis, I note when patterns appear specific to one group and when they cut across both. A fuller discussion of each group’s migration history and reception in Germany is in Appendix H.1.

I recruited participants through snowball sampling, beginning with immigrant organizations and personal networks in Germany. Most interviews were conducted in English; several were conducted in Arabic with the assistance of interpreters who were friends of the participants, as many felt uncomfortable sharing personal experiences in front of strangers.⁸ I detail my position as an interviewer along with the recruitment process and final samples in Appendix H.2 and H.3.

Throughout, I refer to participants by pseudonym, with their interview identifier given at first mention. Pseudonyms were assigned by the author and do not correspond to participants’ names or preferred names. Ages, arrival years, and occupations are reported in bands or broad categories (Table A15).

3.4.1 Results

Contact and Context: Micro-Level Recognition and the Macro-Level Societal Climate Immigrants drew a consistent distinction between their direct personal interactions with native Germans and the broader political and societal climate toward immigration. Participants often described the wider climate as increasingly hostile, especially in connection with the AfD, restrictive policy debates, or anti-immigrant rhetoric, while simultaneously describing their own day-to-day relationships as more stable or supportive. Lina, a Syrian woman, stated this distinction with particular clarity: “No, only in the media. Because the people around me are the same, so they didn’t change, but only in the media we see it.” She was describing a worsening political climate while insisting that the Germans immediately around her had not changed in how they treated her. Khaled, a Syrian man, made a similar distinction in a different register, describing Germany as legally open while adding that “on the ground” the local environment where he arrived was known to be anti-immigrant. Selin, a Turkish student, likewise separated everyday social ties from the broader polit-

⁸When potential interviewees mentioned they did not speak English, I asked whether the friend who introduced us could serve as an interpreter. The interview protocol was approved by University of Illinois Institutional Review Board (IRB25-0018). All participants provided informed consent, received €20 compensation, and chose their preferred language. While not always expected, compensation can be appropriate in contexts where participants may incur costs, such as time, transportation, or emotional labor, especially in one-on-one interview settings (Cramer, 2024), and interviews lasted approximately one to two hours. Names and identifying details have been anonymized.

ical environment, explaining that her trust had declined not because her direct relationships had collapsed, but because she had become more aware of how anti-immigrant politics might affect her future in Germany. Lama, a Syrian woman, also mentioned “I also noticed that when I came in 2022, I didn’t see those signs on the streets. But in 2024, last year, I noticed a lot: a lot of AfD signs and slogans like ‘Germany for Germans.’ I was shocked at first. It wasn’t like that when I first came. I noticed it, but I didn’t take it personally.”

What immigrants reserved the category of *contact* for was something more sustained and relational: interactions with identifiable individuals who had some ongoing presence in their lives, such as colleagues, neighbors, landlords, classmates, or friends. By contrast, discriminatory encounters with strangers, electoral results, media discourse, or generalized anti-immigrant rhetoric were described as features of the *environment* rather than as interpersonal contact. This recurring distinction provides strong support for the study’s conceptual separation of micro-level contact and macro-level context.

Recognition and Misrecognition: The Operative Dimension of Contact Quality Across workplaces, neighborhoods, schools, and friendship networks, the political meaning of contact depended less on whether it was simply positive or negative in tone and more on whether it conveyed recognition or misrecognition (or non-recognition). Positive contact was described as being seen as capable, respectable, and ordinary rather than as a representative of an immigrant category. Negative contact, by contrast, was described as being reduced to a label (refugee, immigrant, foreigner, Arab, Muslim, or non-German speaker) and judged through that label.

Recognition often took the form of practical trust and social reciprocity. Rami, who works in the service sector, described how Germans in his environment came to know him through ordinary roles and repeated contact, which helped him feel less like “the refugee” and more like a normal person moving through German society. Lama reported that she felt more accepted once she was studying and doing research, because others increasingly saw her as someone who could contribute: “Before, when I wasn’t working or studying, I didn’t feel that accepted. Now I feel more accepted.” Positive contact, then, was not just pleasantness; it signaled that one’s presence was legitimate and socially valued.

Misrecognition, by contrast, often appeared in more subtle but politically meaningful forms. The most common negative pattern was not open hostility but *conditional acceptance*: immigrants described being welcomed when they spoke good German, worked hard, followed the rules, or demonstrated professional competence, while still sensing that they never fully shed the immigrant category. Samer, a Syrian man, expressed this especially clearly, explaining that acceptance came “when they see that you integrate,” “when they see that you speak good German,” and “when they see that you have a plan.” Yet he immediately added that even then Germans could “still have this down look for you.” In other words, recognition was often conditional on proof of deservingness, competence, or cultural adaptation. This helps explain why positive interaction and negative misrecognition can coexist rather than forming simple opposites. A third pattern emerged in cases where contact remained largely neutral, neither clearly affirming nor overtly hostile, but superficial. Deniz, a university student, described years of residence in Germany without developing the kind of repeated, embedded ties that communicate recognition. Despite considerable interest in German politics and reasonable knowledge of German political institutions, he continued to describe himself as a guest rather than as a member of the political community. His case suggests that the absence of recognition-bearing contact, not only the presence of misrecognition, can prevent the identity shifts that link interpersonal interaction to political integration. Recognition, in other words, is something that must be actively communicated through sustained contact;

its absence leaves immigrants in a state where political integration does not advance, even when overt hostility is also absent.

Identity Shifts: Decategorization and Recategorization The interviews suggest that contact matters politically when it reshapes how immigrants perceive themselves in relation to German society. Decategorization occurred when interaction with native Germans weakened the salience of the immigrant label and allowed respondents to experience themselves as individuals rather than as undifferentiated outsiders. Yousef, a Syrian man, described his paramedic training as a process of “leveling up,” through which recognition from German teachers and colleagues increased his confidence and lowered the psychological cost of engaging in wider German society. Rami similarly described how being known through concrete everyday roles rather than through refugee status created a sense of normalcy that made social participation feel more natural.

Recategorization went further by producing a sense of shared membership with Germans and, in some cases, a sense of stake in Germany’s future. Faris, a Syrian man who has lived in Germany for about 10 years, was drawn into conversations about elections by his German flatmates, who treated his views as if his relationship to Germany’s future were obvious. Through this sustained contact he came to feel politically and emotionally invested in Germany rather than merely resident in it. Selin articulated the same logic in a more explicit form: as she became more rooted in Germany and discussed politics with German friends, German political developments came to feel increasingly personal rather than external. These interviews suggest that the pathway from contact to political integration is not mechanical. Contact matters when it changes self-perception, first by reducing categorical distance and then, in some cases, by enabling a broader sense of shared membership.

Integration Paradox: When Deeper Ties Often Heighten Awareness of Exclusion The interviews also help explain the reversal pattern in Study 2, where friendship ties with natives corresponded to lower belonging under high societal hostility. In several interviews, deeper integration did not dissolve awareness of exclusion but sharpened it. This was most clearly visible where immigrants had close or trusting ties with Germans while simultaneously becoming more aware of the broader political risks attached to immigration.

Selin is the strongest case. She explained that her trust had declined not because her direct experiences with German friends had worsened, but because she had become more politically aware and more personally exposed: “I feel like the bad things affect me more... not because it actually is going downhill but because I’m more exposed to it.” Watching German election results with German friends made this asymmetry especially visible. Her friends themselves acknowledged that AfD’s rise would affect her more than it would affect them. The friendship did not erase the boundary between personal acceptance and broader exclusion; it made the unequal political stakes clearer and more nameable.

Lama reveals a related dynamic. She described feeling increasingly accepted as she became more integrated through study and research, yet she also said that every encounter with the immigration office reminded her that she was not equal to Germans. In her case, integration generated more recognition in social life while simultaneously clarifying the institutional boundary that remained. These interviews suggest that under hostile conditions, deeper ties with natives can heighten rather than buffer awareness of the gap between interpersonal inclusion and broader societal exclusion. This provides qualitative support for the integration paradox mechanism suggested by Study 2. Mariam illustrates this dynamic in its most extreme form. She had developed one of the strongest native support networks in the entire sample: a German landlord family who

treated her and her newborn daughter as their own. Yet repeated racist incidents in her East German city created a sense of physical and social unsafety that prevented those close ties from consolidating into a sense of belonging. As she put it, one cannot feel at home while still feeling unsafe. Unlike Selin and Lama, whose awareness of exclusion grew alongside their integration, Mariam's case shows that even strong recognition-bearing contact cannot, on its own, override a sufficiently hostile macro-level environment. The contact had initiated the identity shift, but belonging could not consolidate where the broader environment continued to signal that she did not fully belong.

3.4.2 Discussion

The interviews clarify what the survey analyses alone cannot show. Immigrants consistently distinguish between interpersonal contact and the broader societal climate, supporting the study's separation of micro-level contact from macro-level context. They also describe contact in terms of recognition, misrecognition, and non-recognition rather than simply positive or negative tone. Most importantly, the interviews show how contact can shape political integration through changes in self-perception, while also revealing why deeper ties do not always strengthen belonging. Under hostile conditions, close relationships with natives may make the gap between personal acceptance and broader exclusion more visible.

The interviews also point to a form of contact the survey cannot see. Deniz, for instance, has lived in Germany for years with neither much recognition nor much hostility, and still describes himself as a guest. Because Studies 1 and 2 measure positive and negative contact separately, an immigrant low on both is indistinguishable from one whose experiences offset each other, and the absence of recognition may matter in its own right. The qualitative evidence therefore supports the proposed mechanisms and helps explain why contact relates to political integration differently across forms of contact and levels of hostility.

4 Conclusion

The question of how immigrants come to see themselves as members of a political community is not unique to Germany. Across Western democracies, anti-immigrant sentiment is rising and exclusionary positions have spread across party systems (Dancygier & Margalit, 2020), and immigrant-origin populations face growing difficulties integrating into their host societies (Secen & Öztürk, 2025). Much of the existing research focuses on what states do to promote political integration: through formal institutions such as naturalization (Bassel et al., 2021; Hainmueller et al., 2015, 2017), through civic requirements (Goodman & Wright, 2015), or through the settlement policies that determine which local networks immigrants can form in the first place (Bratsberg et al., 2021). I have argued that everyday interactions with natives matter just as much. Whether immigrants feel recognized or looked down on in these routine encounters shapes whether they come to see themselves as legitimate members of the political community.

Drawing on two waves of the SOEP and using optimal full matching with contextual measures linked at the Kreis level, I find that immigrants with more positive interaction with natives tend to have higher political trust, while immigrants who feel looked down on or unappreciated tend to have lower trust in institutions. Immigrants with mostly native friends tend to feel more attached to Germany. These patterns, however, are not the same everywhere, because the two types of hostility do different work. Where the AfD vote is high, immigrants with positive contact trust institutions no more than otherwise similar immigrants. Where natives are very concerned about immigration, the trust difference associated with positive contact is larger, not smaller. Friendship

responds to societal hostility instead: as native concern about immigration rises, the difference in belonging between immigrants with native friends and those with migrant friends narrows and eventually changes direction, so that in the most hostile districts immigrants with mostly native friends feel less attached to Germany than immigrants with mostly migrant friends.

The interviews suggest that these patterns reflect how immigrants themselves experience political integration. Immigrants consistently distinguish between their personal interactions with native Germans and the broader societal climate. They describe contact as meaningful when it communicates recognition, not merely when it is pleasant in tone. And they describe how affirming interactions can gradually shift self-perception, from feeling like an outsider to feeling like a member of the political community, through the processes of decategorization and recategorization. The interviews also show the other side of closeness: in hostile places, native friends are the people through whom immigrants learn how the surrounding society sees their group, so deeper ties bring that rejection closer.

This paper makes three contributions. First, it extends contact theory beyond its usual focus on reducing prejudice among majorities (Choi et al., 2022; Hangartner et al., 2019) toward a minority-centered account of how being recognized by natives relates to how immigrants see themselves politically. Second, it shows that not all hostility works the same way. Where political hostility is high, positive everyday contact and institutional trust are no longer associated; where societal hostility is high, that association survives, and what reverses is the association between native friendship and belonging. Treating hostile context as a single variable would hide both patterns. Third, it offers a micro-level account of the integration paradox. Deeper ties with natives may fail to produce belonging not because they are weak but because they work, bringing immigrants close enough to the majority to see where its acceptance ends (Esaiasson et al., 2024; Schaeffer & Kas, 2024; Verkuyten, 2016).

These findings come with limits. Matching balances the characteristics I observe, but it cannot rule out unmeasured differences between matched immigrants, and the comparisons reported here are adjusted associations, not causal effects. The evidence also comes from one country and from immigrants who arrived after 1995; whether the same patterns hold in other reception contexts is a question I take up in companion work on Belgium. Finally, contact does not relate equally to every dimension of political integration: the patterns are clearest for institutional trust and belonging, and weaker for political efficacy and trust in political actors.

The implications extend beyond Germany. Democratic politics is a group experience, structured by socially embedded communication among different kinds of people (Huckfeldt, 2014). Where political institutions and public debate signal that immigrants do not belong, everyday interactions with natives can either challenge or reinforce that message. This paper opened with Selin's question: if she feels connected to Germans, why shouldn't she feel connected to Germany? In welcoming districts she is right, and Study 2 finds exactly that: immigrants with mostly native friends feel more attached to Germany than their matches. But Selin watched election night with German friends who acknowledged that the AfD's rise would affect her more than it would affect them. Connection to natives is how immigrants come to feel connected to the country. In hostile places, it is also how they learn where the country's welcome ends.

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A Conceptualizing Immigrant Political Integration

For immigrants who join established communities as newcomers, political integration is not merely about formal membership but about gaining recognition and acceptance as legitimate members of the political community. Immigrants must actively interpret signals from the native population to understand their place within the community (Bilodeau & Simonsen, 2024), particularly when immigration is a salient and contested social issue. This process is shaped by a heightened awareness of their subordinate position, as intergroup inequities influence minorities' perceptions, feelings, and political behavior (Honneth, 1996; Pérez & Vicuña, 2023). In hostile contexts, these signals of recognition or exclusion become especially consequential, shaping how immigrants come to see themselves as members of the political community.

Immigrant political integration can be conceptualized as the process by which individuals come to see themselves as part of the political community (Simonsen, 2017). This perspective moves beyond narrow measures like voting (Liu, 2021), focusing instead on whether immigrants feel recognized, valued, and empowered to act politically. I operationalize this through four attitudinal dimensions. **Political belonging** refers to a sense of inclusion and recognition in the host society's politics, reflecting both identification and emotional investment in the political community (Simonsen, 2017). **Political trust** refers to individuals' belief that political institutions and actors will act in the public interest, distinguishing between trust in core state institutions and trust in political actors (Yang et al., 2012). **Political efficacy** captures immigrants' belief in their own competence to understand and participate in politics (Campbell et al., 1971). **Political interest** refers to immigrants' attention to and engagement with political affairs in the host country, reflecting their psychological investment in the political system.⁹ Taken together, these attitudinal dimensions represent immigrants' psychological integration into the political community, which I theorize is shaped by interpersonal contact with natives. However, as I argue below, interaction with natives does not shape all four dimensions uniformly as its effects depend critically on the form of contact and the broader societal and political context in which interactions occur.

B SOEP Samples and Variable Availability

B.1 SOEP Migration and Refugee Samples

To focus on recent immigrants including refugees, I rely on a set of migration and refugee subsamples that have been added to the SOEP:

- Sample M1: immigrants who immigrated to Germany after 1995.
- Sample M2: immigrants who immigrated to Germany between 2010 and 2013.
- Sample M3/M4/M5/M6: refugees who arrived in Germany after January 1, 2013. These samples include both individuals and families and use tailored questionnaires focused on integration experiences, while retaining many of the standard SOEP items.
- Sample M7: expand the coverage of migration dynamics beyond refugees. M7 focuses on EU migrants from Romania, Bulgaria, and Poland who arrived between 2016 and 2018.

⁹This emerged as a key dimension of political integration in the qualitative evidence during my interviews with immigrants in Germany.

- Sample M8: M8a targets third-country nationals who came under Germany’s skilled worker immigration framework between 2017 and 2018, serving as a control group for future evaluations. Sample M8b further supplements the migration sample system by including recent third-country migrants.

Because the SOEP is designed as a longitudinal study with different samples participating in different years and some questionnaires overlapping while others are unique to specific samples, my empirical strategy is to conduct multiple studies to test the theory and to establish robustness across various subsamples and survey years by tailoring each analysis to the available data structure and variable coverage.

B.2 Variable Availability Across Survey Years

Variable	2021	2022
Measures for Positive/Negative Contact		
Proportion of Native friends		✓
Positive/Negative Interaction in Daily Lives	✓	
Measures for Political Integration		
Political trust	✓	
Political efficacy	✓	
Political interest	✓	
Sense of Belonging		✓
Measures for Hostile Context		
Perceived Hostility	✓	✓
Regional variables	✓	✓

Table A1: Availability of key variables by SOEP survey year (M3–M8).

C Sample

As Table A2 and A3 show, four groups of immigrants participated in the surveys. In 2021, most of respondents were early immigrants, followed by economic immigrants, EU migrants, and refugees. In 2022, economic immigrants were the largest group in the survey, followed by refugees, early immigrants and EU migrants. The two samples differ not only in size but also in their migration background, which is why the two studies are analyzed separately.

D Factor Analyses for Interaction Settings

For situations of feelings of appreciation/misrecognition, appreciation took place at workplace (49.8%), government agencies (6.21%), on the street (12.0%), in the family (55.6%), among friends (51.7%), leisure time (13.8%), social media (5.9%), and others (0.9%). When it comes to negative interaction (not being appreciated), interaction often take place at workplace (30.4%), government agencies (18.1%), on the street (16.1%), in the family (12.6%), among friends (10.6%), leisure time (4.6%), social media (4.8%), and others (1.4%).

Table A2: Descriptive Statistics by Migration Status (2021)

variable	EU.Migrants	Early.Immigrants	Economic.Immigrants	Refugees
N	222	1365	437	183
Citizenship	0.03	0.56	0.02	0.05
Migration Year	4.34	18.10	2.92	5.67
Age	36.50	43.05	33.73	23.97
Education	4.00	3.00	6.00	2.00
Income	3116.92	3426.80	3047.54	2231.16
West Germany	0.86	0.87	0.81	0.86
Political Efficacy	1.09	1.11	1.07	1.09
Political Trust	4.93	5.10	5.77	6.20
Appreciation	8.32	8.31	8.12	7.77
Misrecognition	5.39	4.89	5.19	5.65
Perceived Hostility	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00
Language Proficiency	2.00	3.00	3.00	3.00

Table A3: Friendship Composition by Migration Status (2022)

Var1	Early Immigrants	Economic Immigrants	EU Migrants	Refugees
All migrants	234	946	54	783
Mostly migrants	179	883	32	424
More migrants	214	551	39	393
More German	84	147	7	123
Mostly German	89	203	8	119
All German	151	243	23	114

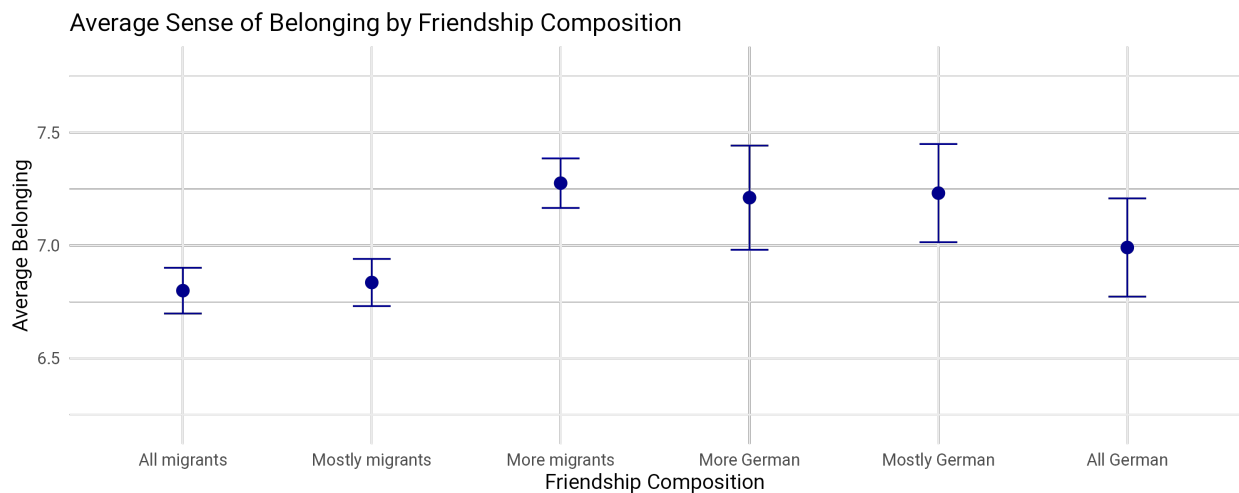


Figure A1: Average Sense of Belonging by Friendship Composition

To uncover the underlying structure of these patterns, I conducted separate exploratory factor analyses for the settings in which feelings of appreciation and misrecognition occur (Table A4).

	F1: Relational (Private)	Public or Institutional
Workplace	0.26	
Government		0.47
Street		0.45
Family	0.63	-0.12
Friends	0.72	
Leisure	0.29	0.35
Media	0.11	0.43
Other	-0.15	0.39

Table A4: Exploratory Factor Analysis for Setting Where Positive Contact Occurs

For positive interactions, the factor structure revealed a clear two-dimensional pattern. Factor 1 reflects relational (private) appreciation, encompassing family, friends, and—though with weaker cross-loadings—the workplace. Factor 2 reflects public or institutional appreciation, including experiences in government agencies, on the street, and through media.

	F1: Informal/Everyday	F2: Relational	F3: Institutional
Workplace			0.18
Government			0.72
Street	0.18		0.30
Family		0.76	
Friends	0.22	0.35	
Leisure	0.49	0.09	
Media	0.55		
Other	0.43		

Table A5: Exploratory Factor Analysis for Setting Where Negative Contact Occurs

For negative interactions, the factor structure was more diffuse, producing three distinct dimensions (Table A5). Factor 1 captures informal and everyday exclusion, including leisure activities, media, and other contexts. Factor 2 reflects private relational exclusion, centered on family and to some extent friends. Factor 3 corresponds to institutional exclusion, particularly from government agencies, with the workplace also emerging as a notable setting.

D.1 Distribution of Contact Indices and Exposure Cutpoints

Figure A2 shows the distribution of the four component items underlying the positive and negative contact indices, with the mean marked. Positive-contact items concentrate toward the high end of the scale, while negative-contact items concentrate toward the low end.

E Matching Diagnostics

E.1 Study 1: Positive and Negative Contact

For Study 1 (2021), I ran four separate matching procedures, for positive and negative contact, each matched on either political hostility (AfD support) or societal hostility (native attitudes). In every procedure I matched by optimal full matching (Hansen, 2004) on the estimated propensity score,

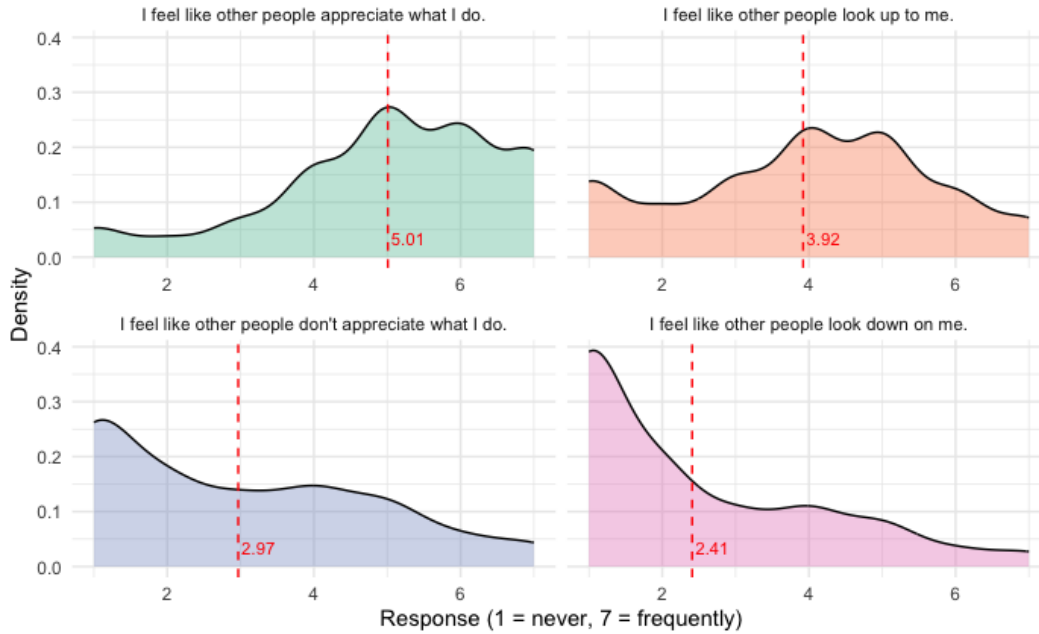


Figure A2: Quality of Contact in Everyday Experiences

Note: Density of responses to the four contact items (1 = never, 7 = frequently). Red dashed lines mark average of each question. The positive contact index sums the two appreciation items; the negative index sums the two misrecognition items.

restricting matches to immigrants within a caliper on both the propensity-score distance and a rank-based Mahalanobis distance. The propensity score and Mahalanobis distance were computed over age, gender, years since migration, EU origin, citizenship, education, German proficiency, logged household income, West Germany residence, proportion of foreigners in the district, early arrival, the other dimension of contact, the relevant hostility measure, and missingness indicators for migration year, education, and household income.

For positive contact matched on political hostility, the omnibus d^2 balance test (Hansen & Bowers, 2008) yielded a p-value of 0.99 with an effective sample size of 567.5 (Table A6). For positive contact matched on societal hostility, the test resulted in a p-value of 0.999 with an effective sample size of 547.9 (Table A7).

For negative contact matched on political hostility, the test yielded a p-value of 0.996 with an effective sample size of 452.4 (Table A8), and for negative contact matched on societal hostility, a p-value of 0.998 with an effective sample size of 458.8 (Table A9). These results suggest that all four matching procedures were successful in creating comparable groups for analysis.

E.2 Study 2: Friendship

For Study 2 (2022), matching was conducted on friendship with natives using the same covariate structure. Matched on political hostility, the balance test yielded a p-value of 0.99 with an effective sample size of 1239.9 (Table A10), and matched on societal hostility, a p-value of 0.996 with an effective sample size of 1223.4 (Table A11). Both matching procedures were successful in producing well-balanced comparison groups.

Table A6: Matching Balance: Positive Contact, Political Hostility (2021)

Variable	Unexposed	Exposed	std.diff	adj.diff	pooled.sd	z	p
Age	38.448	38.474	0.002	0.026	11.649	-0.250	1
EU Origin	0.528	0.495	-0.066	-0.033	0.500	-0.948	1
Migration Year	11.240	11.481	0.030	0.241	8.155	-0.458	1
Citizenship	0.395	0.390	-0.010	-0.005	0.480	-0.667	1
West Germany	0.859	0.846	-0.033	-0.013	0.376	-0.298	1
Proportion of Foreigners	15.351	15.281	-0.012	-0.071	5.916	-0.330	1
Early Arrival	0.624	0.625	0.002	0.001	0.487	-0.670	1
log(Income)	8.048	8.054	0.010	0.006	0.624	0.518	1
Education	4.286	4.284	-0.001	-0.002	1.743	0.174	1
Female	0.509	0.502	-0.014	-0.007	0.500	-0.171	1
Negative Contact	4.661	4.633	-0.009	-0.028	3.001	0.105	1
German Proficiency	0.744	0.734	-0.021	-0.010	0.449	-0.089	1
Migration Year.NA	0.244	0.240	-0.010	-0.004	0.421	-0.560	1
Education.NA	0.042	0.048	0.027	0.006	0.226	-0.141	1
log(Income).NA	0.036	0.039	0.012	0.003	0.217	-0.236	1
Hostility	0.087	0.088	0.024	0.001	0.045	0.324	1

F Supplementary Analyses

F.1 Baseline Association Between Contact and Integration

Table A7: Matching Balance: Positive Contact, Societal Hostility (2021)

Variable	Unexposed	Exposed	std.diff	adj.diff	pooled.sd	z	p
Age	38.137	38.474	0.029	0.338	11.649	-0.014	1
EU Origin	0.490	0.495	0.009	0.005	0.500	-0.064	1
Migration Year	10.940	11.481	0.066	0.542	8.155	0.718	1
Citizenship	0.366	0.390	0.050	0.024	0.480	0.438	1
West Germany	0.849	0.846	-0.008	-0.003	0.376	-0.136	1
Proportion of Foreigners	14.915	15.281	0.062	0.366	5.916	0.334	1
Early Arrival	0.612	0.625	0.027	0.013	0.487	0.330	1
log(Income)	8.043	8.054	0.017	0.011	0.624	0.202	1
Education	4.344	4.284	-0.035	-0.060	1.743	-0.622	1
Female	0.496	0.502	0.012	0.006	0.500	0.582	1
Negative Contact	4.605	4.633	0.009	0.028	3.001	0.299	1
German Proficiency	0.734	0.734	0.000	0.000	0.449	0.927	1
Migration Year.NA	0.238	0.240	0.003	0.001	0.421	-0.140	1
Education.NA	0.048	0.048	0.002	0.000	0.226	0.035	1
log(Income).NA	0.033	0.039	0.028	0.006	0.217	0.354	1
Hostility	0.730	0.718	-0.061	-0.012	0.198	-0.335	1

Table A8: Matching Balance: Negative Contact, Political Hostility (2021)

Variable	Unexposed	Exposed	std.diff	adj.diff	pooled.sd	z	p
Age	37.115	37.121	0.000	0.005	12.054	-0.445	1
EU Origin	0.409	0.426	0.033	0.016	0.497	0.305	1
Migration Year	11.643	12.152	0.057	0.509	8.899	0.075	1
Citizenship	0.304	0.329	0.052	0.025	0.481	0.287	1
West Germany	0.819	0.822	0.008	0.003	0.365	0.104	1
Proportion of Foreigners	15.384	15.144	-0.041	-0.240	5.889	-0.953	1
Early Arrival	0.535	0.561	0.053	0.026	0.488	0.073	1
log(Income)	7.874	7.871	-0.004	-0.003	0.639	-0.534	1
Education	3.799	3.766	-0.020	-0.034	1.716	-0.175	1
Female	0.543	0.519	-0.049	-0.024	0.500	-0.433	1
Positive Contact	8.277	8.268	-0.003	-0.010	2.783	-0.214	1
German Proficiency	0.662	0.671	0.020	0.009	0.454	0.676	1
Migration Year.NA	0.154	0.191	0.089	0.037	0.417	1.116	1
Education.NA	0.058	0.071	0.053	0.012	0.234	0.248	1
log(Income).NA	0.051	0.069	0.079	0.018	0.227	0.593	1
Hostility	0.088	0.090	0.046	0.002	0.042	0.336	1

Table A9: Matching Balance: Negative Contact, Societal Hostility (2021)

Variable	Unexposed	Exposed	std.diff	adj.diff	pooled.sd	z	p
Age	37.506	37.121	-0.032	-0.385	12.054	-0.841	1
EU Origin	0.388	0.426	0.075	0.037	0.497	0.457	1
Migration Year	12.169	12.152	-0.002	-0.017	8.899	-0.166	1
Citizenship	0.297	0.329	0.066	0.032	0.481	0.642	1
West Germany	0.838	0.822	-0.045	-0.016	0.365	-0.002	1
Proportion of Foreigners	15.074	15.144	0.012	0.070	5.889	0.580	1
Early Arrival	0.554	0.561	0.015	0.007	0.488	-0.222	1
log(Income)	7.861	7.871	0.015	0.010	0.639	-0.062	1
Education	3.797	3.766	-0.018	-0.031	1.716	-0.806	1
Female	0.511	0.519	0.015	0.008	0.500	0.144	1
Positive Contact	8.313	8.268	-0.016	-0.045	2.783	0.253	1
German Proficiency	0.661	0.671	0.023	0.010	0.454	0.708	1
Migration Year.NA	0.147	0.191	0.107	0.045	0.417	1.397	1
Education.NA	0.060	0.071	0.045	0.011	0.234	0.479	1
log(Income).NA	0.066	0.069	0.014	0.003	0.227	0.119	1
Hostility	0.733	0.732	-0.007	-0.001	0.196	-0.209	1

Table A10: Matching Balance: Friendship, Political Hostility (2022)

Variable	Unexposed	Exposed	std.diff	adj.diff	pooled.sd	z	p
Age	35.189	36.037	0.077	0.848	10.945	0.393	1
EU Origin	0.270	0.270	-0.002	-0.001	0.370	0.003	1
Migration Year	7.150	7.361	0.034	0.210	6.138	0.146	1
Citizenship	0.241	0.246	0.012	0.005	0.367	-1.005	1
West Germany	0.831	0.807	-0.061	-0.024	0.393	-0.134	1
Proportion of Foreigners	17.547	17.402	-0.023	-0.145	6.308	-0.766	1
log(Income)	7.839	7.849	0.012	0.010	0.875	-0.083	1
Education	3.919	4.005	0.043	0.086	1.987	-0.212	1
Female	0.476	0.470	-0.012	-0.006	0.500	-0.197	1
Refugee	0.258	0.246	-0.027	-0.012	0.453	-0.427	1
Migration Year.NA	0.283	0.271	-0.031	-0.012	0.397	-0.489	1
Education.NA	0.106	0.104	-0.004	-0.001	0.309	-0.043	1
log(Income).NA	0.088	0.074	-0.053	-0.014	0.258	0.073	1
Hostility	0.087	0.091	0.077	0.003	0.044	0.822	1

Table A11: Matching Balance: Friendship, Societal Hostility (2022)

Variable	Unexposed	Exposed	std.diff	adj.diff	pooled.sd	z	p
Age	35.667	36.037	0.034	0.369	10.945	-0.054	1
EU Origin	0.268	0.270	0.004	0.001	0.370	0.392	1
Migration Year	7.200	7.361	0.026	0.161	6.138	0.228	1
Citizenship	0.232	0.246	0.036	0.013	0.367	-0.681	1
West Germany	0.806	0.807	0.002	0.001	0.393	0.181	1
Proportion of Foreigners	17.317	17.402	0.013	0.085	6.308	-0.287	1
log(Income)	7.807	7.849	0.048	0.042	0.875	0.244	1
Education	3.908	4.005	0.049	0.097	1.987	0.386	1
Female	0.471	0.470	-0.002	-0.001	0.500	0.286	1
Refugee	0.253	0.246	-0.017	-0.008	0.453	-0.670	1
Migration Year.NA	0.283	0.271	-0.031	-0.012	0.397	-0.083	1
Education.NA	0.109	0.104	-0.015	-0.005	0.309	0.067	1
log(Income).NA	0.075	0.074	-0.004	-0.001	0.258	0.078	1
Hostility	0.762	0.768	0.030	0.006	0.205	0.126	1

Table A12: Contact with Natives and Political Integration

		Matched Context	
Contact	Outcome	Political	Societal
Positive Contact			
Positive contact	Political interest	0.127* (0.050)	0.082+ (0.049)
Positive contact	Political efficacy	0.007 (0.025)	0.007 (0.025)
Positive contact	Trust in institutions	0.275* (0.130)	0.162 (0.135)
Positive contact	Trust in political actors	0.208 (0.149)	0.079 (0.151)
Negative Contact			
Negative contact	Political interest	0.016 (0.057)	0.007 (0.055)
Negative contact	Political efficacy	-0.022 (0.026)	-0.035 (0.025)
Negative contact	Trust in institutions	-0.393** (0.152)	-0.428** (0.153)
Negative contact	Trust in political actors	-0.191 (0.164)	-0.286+ (0.160)

Entries are coefficient estimates with standard errors in parentheses. Models include matched-set fixed effects. Political context refers to AfD-matched sets; societal context refers to native-attitudes-matched sets. + $p < 0.10$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$.

G Robustness and Sensitivity Analyses (Individual-Covariate Design)

G.1 Robustness Check

The main analyses involve several design decisions that could reasonably have been made differently. In Study 1, I define high versus low contact using the median of each contact index. In Study 2, I exclude respondents with mixed friendship networks and compare those with predominantly native friends to those with predominantly migrant friends. This section re-estimates the headline results using alternative cutpoints in Study 1 and including the previously excluded respondents in Study 2. The purpose is to assess whether the direction and statistical significance of the main associations remain consistent across alternative treatment definitions and sample specifications.

The district-linked covariates (political hostility, societal hostility, and district-level foreigner share) as well as the district identifiers required to cluster standard errors at the Kreis level are available only through restricted on-site access at DIW Berlin. Accordingly, the analyses in this section use a parallel matched design based on individual-level covariates alone, with standard errors clustered at the matched-set level. The full specifications, including district-linked covariates and Kreis-level clustering, will be re-estimated through the secure facility. As a point of comparison, the individual-covariate design using the main treatment definitions closely reproduces the reported estimates in both studies.

Table A13: Robustness of main results across exposure definitions

Exposure definition	Exposed / Unexposed	N (matched)	Effective Sample Size	Outcomes	p
<i>Study 1: Positive Contact and Political Trust</i>					
Index > 8	759 / 481	1,238	511	0.337 (0.141)**	.017
Index > 9 (main)	620 / 620	1,238	531	0.260 (0.133)*	.051
Index > 10	424 / 814	1,236	471	0.320 (0.140)**	.023
<i>Study 1: Negative Contact and Political Trust</i>					
Index > 5	632 / 416	1,039	407.8	−0.566 (0.152)***	< .001
Index > 6 (main)	513 / 537	1,035	423.7	−0.284 (0.156)*	.070
Index > 7	389 / 639	1,036	418.2	−0.381 (0.152)**	.012
<i>Study 2: Friends with Natives and Belonging</i>					
1–2 vs. 5–6 (main)	3,367 / 909	4,241	1179.8	0.254 (0.092)***	.006
1–3 vs. 4–6 (incl. mixed)	4,489 / 1,247	5,708	1,648.3	0.168 (0.076)**	.028

Note: Each row is a separately re-matched sample using the identical matching procedure as the main analysis (optimal full matching on the propensity score with rank-based Mahalanobis distance, exact matching, and calipers), excluding district-linked covariates. Matched-set fixed effects; CR2 standard errors clustered at the matched set, in parentheses. Omnibus covariate balance tests fail to reject in every variant (all $p > 0.95$); effective sample sizes (equivalent number of matched pairs) in column ESS. Exposed/unexposed counts are pre-matching. The friendship variant redefines the exposure contrast rather than moving a cutpoint: respondents with mixed networks (3–4) enter the comparison, with exposure defined as German-leaning networks (4–6). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

G.2 Sensitivity Analyses

Matching improves comparability between treated and control respondents on observed characteristics, but it cannot eliminate bias from unobserved confounders. Unobserved factors may affect both respondents' likelihood of contact with natives and their levels of political integration. I therefore conduct Rosenbaum sensitivity analyses (Rosenbaum, 2025) to assess how strongly an

unmeasured factor would have to influence treatment assignment within matched sets to alter the statistical conclusions.

The analysis uses a sensitivity parameter, Γ , which bounds the extent to which treatment assignment may differ between respondents within the same matched set (Zhao, 2019). Two respondents who are identical on all matched covariates may nevertheless differ in their odds of treatment by a factor of up to Γ because of an unobserved characteristic. When $\Gamma = 1$, the analysis assumes no hidden bias in treatment assignment within matched sets. As Γ increases, it permits progressively larger departures from this assumption and calculates the corresponding worst-case p -value bound (Rosenbaum, 2025). The analyses use the same individual-covariate matched samples as the robustness checks. I conduct one-sided tests in the direction specified by each hypothesis and report upper bounds on the one-sided p -values at the 0.05 level. The analysis focuses on the three statistically distinguishable associations that constitute the paper’s main empirical findings: positive contact and institutional trust, negative contact and institutional trust, and friendship with natives and a sense of belonging.

Table A14: Sensitivity of the main associations to unmeasured bias

	Positive contact → trust in institutions	Negative contact → trust in institutions	Friendship → belonging
p -value bound at $\Gamma = 1.00$	.025	.028	.002
p -value bound at $\Gamma = 1.05$	.062	.061	.009
p -value bound at $\Gamma = 1.10$	.129	.117	.033
p -value bound at $\Gamma = 1.15$	.227	.197	.092
p -value bound at $\Gamma = 1.20$	.352	.299	.199
Sensitivity value Γ^*	1.03	1.03	1.11

Note: One-sided p -value upper bounds from the full-matching sensitivity analysis of Rosenbaum (2007), computed using the matched samples reported in robustness check. Γ^* is the largest value of Γ , evaluated on a grid in increments of 0.005, at which the upper bound remains at or below 0.05; values are rounded down to two decimal places. The sensitivity analyses use one-sided tests in the hypothesized direction (Rosenbaum, 2025). Because the main tables report two-sided regression tests, the p -value bounds at $\Gamma = 1$ differ from the corresponding main-model p -values.

Table A14 shows that the findings differ substantially in their sensitivity to unmeasured bias. For both positive and negative contact, $\Gamma^* = 1.03$. An unmeasured factor that changes the odds of exposure within matched sets by approximately 3 percent could therefore raise the worst-case one-sided p -value above 0.05. These results should be interpreted as adjusted associations that remain vulnerable to modest unmeasured confounding. The friendship–belonging association in Study 2 is comparatively less sensitive, remaining statistically distinguishable from zero up to $\Gamma^* = 1.11$. Nevertheless, this result also remains vulnerable to plausible unmeasured confounding and should not be interpreted as establishing a causal effect.

H Study 3: Interviews

H.1 Samples: Why Turkish and Syrian Immigrants?

I focus on Turkish and Syrian immigrants because they represent two distinct migration history and trajectories in Europe. Immigration has long been a central issue in European political discourse, with Muslim immigrants frequently positioned at the center of anti-immigrant sentiment.

This hostility is often driven by a perception that Muslims hold ideological and normative values that fundamentally differ from those of Christian-majority societies (Choi et al., 2022). Native populations may fear that immigrants will undermine national culture and fail to respect dominant norms and traditions, fueling anxiety, antipathy, and discriminatory attitudes (Hagendoorn & Sniderman, 2001). While Syrian immigrants have largely arrived as asylum seekers fleeing conflict, Turkish immigrants in this study enter host societies with different legal pathways and integration experiences and belong to a broader, long-established Turkish diaspora in Europe. In contrast to Syrians, whose migration has been largely shaped by asylum policies, recent Turkish immigrants include a diverse mix of economic migrants, political exiles, and other voluntary movers. These differing migration pathways have led to varying policy responses, legal classifications, and public perceptions.

As Kunuroglu et al. (2018) note, the political and economic contexts of both origin and settlement countries shape how migrants conceptualize their experiences and construct their collective identities. By examining these two groups, this study provides a comparative analysis of how first-generation immigrants, one group embedded in an existing diaspora (Turks) and another arriving as newly displaced refugees (Syrians), navigate interacting with the host society.

Turkish Immigrants Turkish immigrants constitute the largest non-European, non-Christian minority group in Europe and form one of the most established Muslim communities on the continent. While earlier generations of Turkish migrants arrived as guest workers during the postwar economic boom of the 1960s and 1970s, migration from Turkey has remained a continuous process, with new waves of immigrants entering European host societies for various economic, political, and personal reasons. Research has shown that Turkish immigrants in Europe, regardless of their length of residence, have faced racist discrimination, prejudice, and barriers in education, employment, and housing (Kunuroglu et al., 2018). Their visibility as a Muslim community has further contributed to their racialization and marginalization, particularly in the aftermath of 9/11 and subsequent terrorist attacks, which reinforced Islamophobic discourses in Western media.

While long-established Turkish communities have built institutions, businesses, and networks that offer support to newer arrivals, recent migrants do not automatically benefit from these structures, particularly when their migration is driven by different economic or political circumstances. Unlike second-generation Turks, who may hold European citizenship and have undergone formal education in their host countries, newer first-generation immigrants must navigate complex legal, social, and political landscapes to secure economic stability and social belonging.

Syrian Immigrants Syrian immigrants represent a more recent wave of migration, arriving primarily after 2011 due to the Syrian civil war. While many initially sought refuge in neighboring countries (Vause & Schoumaker, n.d.), many eventually moved to Western Europe, with Germany and Belgium becoming key destinations. Unlike Turkish immigrants, who arrived under structured labor recruitment programs and have long-established networks, Syrians entered primarily through asylum policies and humanitarian frameworks, leading to distinct legal, social, and economic integration challenges. Many of them have refugee backgrounds and their displacement was largely involuntary, marked by traumatic experiences such as torture, destruction of homes, and loss of livelihoods, which can have lasting psychological effects and contribute to persistent stresses post-resettlement (Hunkler & Khourshed, 2020; Renner et al., 2021; Von Haumeder et al., 2019; Zbidat et al., 2020). These vulnerabilities, combined with bureaucratic hurdles in host countries, have shaped their integration experiences in unique ways.

Germany has been one of the main destinations for Syrian refugees, particularly during the

2015–2016 immigration wave. At that time, Syrians were among the largest groups of asylum seekers in the country, and the German government granted many of them the legal right to stay. Today, Syrians are the third-largest foreign population in Germany (Hunkler & Khourshed, 2020), and a growing number have acquired German citizenship. At the start of the 2015 refugee crisis, Syrians were often welcomed with a sense of humanitarian responsibility, and many Germans took pride in their country's commitment to providing refuge. However, over time, this welcoming sentiment shifted to increasing hostility, fueled by public anxiety over cultural integration, security concerns, and economic pressures. The rise of far-right parties, particularly the Alternative for Germany (AfD), coincided with a growing backlash against refugees, positioning Syrians as one of the main targets of anti-immigrant rhetoric (Pearlman, 2017).

The German asylum system introduced policies that further shaped the integration trajectories of Syrian refugees. Upon arrival, Germany allocated refugees to one of the 16 federal states through a quota system and restricted their mobility (Schilling & Stillman, 2024). After registration in the assigned state, refugees were further distributed to municipalities within the state based on quotas. Later, movement across states was permitted (Katz et al., 2016). These sub-national variations in reception and integration policies provide an opportunity to study how different local contexts influence immigrant experiences. Despite legal pathways to naturalization, many Syrian refugees remain within co-ethnic networks, interacting primarily with other refugees rather than with the native German population.

Unlike Turkish immigrants, who have faced long-term discrimination but have established community networks, Syrians have experienced a rapid shift from an initially welcoming environment to growing hostility. In 2015, many Syrians saw Germany as a haven offering freedom and dignity, while many Germans celebrated their country's humanitarian stance. However, since then, integration challenges, bureaucratic obstacles, and rising anti-immigrant sentiment have complicated their experience (Pearlman, 2017). While Turkish immigrants have been historically exposed to anti-Muslim prejudice, their long-standing presence has led to different levels of hostility over time. In contrast, Syrians have gone from a period of welcome to being among the most prominent targets of anti-immigrant discourse in just a few years. This dramatic shift in public perception makes them a crucial group for understanding how political and social contexts shape immigrant integration in Western Europe.

H.2 Sampling, Recruitment, and Language

I recruited participants through snowball sampling, beginning with immigrant organizations, personal contacts, and referrals from scholars with migration backgrounds in Germany. Snowball sampling is widely used for reaching populations that are heterogeneous, dispersed, or partially hidden, particularly when trust-building is necessary for discussing sensitive topics (Khoury, 2024). At the same time, the method has well-known limitations. It tends to favor individuals with larger social networks and may reproduce the biases of initial contact points across subsequent recruitment waves (Khoury, 2024).

These dynamics were evident in my own recruitment process. Although Germany hosts a large immigrant population, access was not straightforward. Initial contacts were often relatively well-integrated immigrants who spoke strong English, had prior experience participating in interviews, or were international students. In this sense, the first recruitment seeds were not necessarily representative of the broader immigrant population of interest. However, as recruitment proceeded through participants' own networks, I was increasingly able to reach individuals who are often difficult to access through conventional academic recruitment channels, including mothers caring for multiple children at home and individuals with more limited English proficiency.

I interviewed first-generation immigrants who arrived in Germany after 2014. Among the 18 interviewees in Germany, 12 were from Syria (8 men and 4 women) and 6 were from Turkey (1 man and 5 women). I did not seek to restrict regional variation within Germany, as contextual variation also provides analytical leverage for understanding how immigrants perceive and interpret their surrounding environments across different regions.

Interviewees ranged in age from 19 to their late 30s, with an average age of 28.7. In terms of occupation, the sample included university students, skilled professionals, and workers, including a dentist, pharmacist, engineer, researcher, logistics worker, and participants with backgrounds in NGO and humanitarian work. This diversity provided variation in both life stage and degree of incorporation into German society.

Interviews were conducted primarily in English. For participants with lower English proficiency, interviews were adapted flexibly to ensure comfort and comprehension, with communication adjusted to participants' language abilities rather than imposing strict linguistic requirements.

At the same time, some limitations in access remained. Older recent immigrants were relatively rare within the target population and, when identified, were often less willing to discuss personal migration experiences with a researcher, resulting in some refusals. As a result, the sample skews younger, which reflects both the composition of recent immigrant cohorts and differential willingness to participate.

The Turkish subsample also reflects the composition of recent migration flows. Because the study focuses on immigrants arriving after 2014, most Turkish participants differed from the larger, more established Turkish-origin population in Germany whose migration histories trace back to the guestworker era of the 1960s and 1970s. Recent Turkish immigrants were more likely to be highly educated or professionally skilled, meaning the Turkish subsample should not be interpreted as representative of the broader Turkish-origin population in Germany. More broadly, while snowball recruitment improved access to a diverse range of participants over time, the sample should be understood as analytically diverse rather than statistically representative.

H.3 Positionality

Existing research demonstrates that interviewer identity systematically shapes how respondents engage with sensitive topics (Adida et al., 2016). The researcher is not a neutral instrument in the research process; rather, interviewer identity shapes what participants are willing to disclose, how interactions unfold, and how resulting data should be interpreted (Thomas, 2024). While I interviewed Syrian and Turkish immigrants currently living in Germany, I am neither Syrian, Turkish, nor German. Instead, I entered the field as an Asian woman, a PhD student at an American institution, and an outsider to both participants' co-ethnic communities and the German host society. I shared neither participants' ethnic or religious backgrounds nor the position of a native German researcher.

This positionality likely shaped disclosure in several ways. Because I was perceived as external to participants' immediate social and institutional worlds, some respondents may have felt lower social costs in discussing sensitive topics. Participants openly criticized co-ethnic communities, expressed ambivalence toward German society, and described interpersonal or family tensions in ways that might have been more guarded with a co-ethnic interviewer or someone embedded in institutions they associated with authority, service provision, or immigration governance. Several participants appeared to view me primarily as an international academic researcher rather than someone connected to local gatekeeping institutions, which may have facilitated candor.

At the same time, my position also created forms of access that may not be equally available to all researchers. As a woman researcher, I was able to reach participants who are often underrep-

Table A15: Interview Participants, Germany

ID	Pseudonym	Origin	Gender	Age	Arrival	Occupation	Region
DE#1	Faris	Syria	M	35–39	2014–16	Professional	North/East
DE#2	Khaled	Syria	M	35–39	2020–22	Professional	South
DE#3	Lina	Syria	F	25–29	2014–16	Other	West/Central
DE#4	Nabil	Syria	M	30–34	2020–22	Other	South
DE#5	Merve	Turkey	F	19–24	2023–24	Student	North/East
DE#6	Mariam	Syria	F	30–34	2017–19	Professional	North/East
DE#7	Samer	Syria	M	30–34	2020–22	Service / manual	West/Central
DE#8	Yousef	Syria	M	30–34	2020–22	Service / manual	West/Central
DE#9	Bassel	Syria	M	25–29	2014–16	Other	West/Central
DE#10	Hala	Syria	F	35–39	2017–19	Professional	West/Central
DE#11	Tarek	Syria	M	30–34	2014–16	Professional	West/Central
DE#12	Elif	Turkey	F	25–29	2023–24	Student	South
DE#13	Selin	Turkey	F	19–24	2023–24	Student	South
DE#14	Esra	Turkey	F	19–24	2023–24	Student	South
DE#15	Pelin	Turkey	F	25–29	2020–22	Student	South
DE#16	Rami	Syria	M	19–24	2020–22	Service / manual	South
DE#17	Lama	Syria	F	35–39	2020–22	Professional	West/Central
DE#18	Deniz	Turkey	M	19–24	2023–24	Student	South

Note: Names are pseudonyms. Pseudonyms were assigned by the author and bear no relation to participants' actual names. Ages and arrival years are reported in bands, and occupation is grouped into broad categories, to protect participant confidentiality given the small and networked sample. Region refers to the broad area of residence within Germany. IDs correspond to in-text references.

resented in research on immigrant integration, particularly women outside formal employment. Recruitment through workplace or institutional channels frequently misses this population, and some women may be less comfortable speaking with male researchers or unfamiliar outsiders. Snowball recruitment through immigrant women's networks enabled access to participants in this category, including mothers caring for children at home, who had to do an interview in their private place, may have otherwise remained outside conventional sampling frames.

This does not eliminate sampling limitations, nor does it imply that my identity uniformly improved access. Rather, it shaped both the kinds of participants I could reach and the types of narratives participants may have been willing to share. These dynamics should be understood as part of the empirical conditions under which the interview data were produced.